

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Gender Discrimination - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section A | 32 diagnostics, 12 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Gender Discrimination - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Gender Discrimination learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Gender Discrimination : Female Foeticide, Land and Property Rights; Empowerment.* - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Section A, item 9. One concept and three applications are printed, and the relation between them is the whole examination: the heading is a conceptual demand about what turns a bodily difference into a social hierarchy, while the three applications are the sites at which the paper insists the concept be tested - the valuation of female life before birth, the ownership and control of land and property, and the expansion of women's power to make and act on significant choices. It does not own general abortion doctrine, medical technique, succession law in detail, scheme administration or gender statistics. It owns the prior philosophical questions: **what gender is, how a difference becomes a subordination, what would count as a remedy, and what would have to be true before anyone could say the remedy had worked.** Full theories of equality, justice and liberty belong to **Social and Political Ideals**; complete liberalism, Marxism, socialism and anarchism to **Political Ideologies**; recognition and plural belonging as doctrines to **Humanism, Secularism and Multiculturalism**; the general capability framework to **Development and Social Progress**; graded caste hierarchy and its annihilation to **Caste Discrimination: Gandhi and Ambedkar**; rights, duties and accountability to **Individual and State** - all routed rather than developed. Detailed succession and family law, medical practice, scheme design and any demographic dataset belong to the Polity, Governance and Social Justice areas and lie outside this owner entirely.

Evidence discipline: FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction offered for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute or a contested empirical claim. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II.

Terminology and citation rule: the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *bodily and reproductive characteristics (sex), socially produced roles, expectations and identities (gender), the patterned ranking of masculinised over feminised roles and persons (gender hierarchy), a social order in which authority, property and interpretation are systematically held by men (patriarchy), the constitution of woman as the inessential term against a male norm (the Other), gender produced through compelled, reiterated stylised acts (performativity), the provisional political use of a category known to be historically constructed (strategic essentialism), the same rule applied to all (formal equality), attention to unequal starting positions, burdens and effective outcomes (substantive equality), citizens meeting without domination, stigma or servility (relational equality), the choice between a sex-neutral rule and accommodation (the sameness/difference dilemma), wrong reproduced by many ordinary actions inside normal institutions without one sole author (structural injustice), forward-looking shared duties graded by power, privilege, interest and capacity (the social-connection model), the prior arrangement securing men's access to women's bodies and labour that contract theory leaves unmentioned (the sexual contract), the termination of a pregnancy because the foetus is identified or presumed to be female (female foeticide), killing after birth, legally and conceptually distinct (female infanticide), the demographic absence produced by unequal care, nutrition, health access and selection (the missing-women deficit), legal recognition of a claim (title), the ability to reach and use the asset (access), the power to decide about it (control), receipt of the income (return), the capacity of an asset to protect against abandonment or violence (exit/security), what a person could command if the relationship ended (fall-back position), the model in which household allocation is negotiated rather than decided by a single altruistic head (intra-household bargaining), preconditions such as education, health, time, income, property and networks (resources), voice, choice, bargaining, mobility and bodily decision (agency), the functionings actually realised (achievements), the decisions about marriage, childbearing, work, movement and one's own body on which a life is built (strategic life choices), the downward adjustment of reported satisfaction under long deprivation (adaptive preferences), unequal income, property, time, care burden and material security (the redistributive dimension), devaluation, stereotyping and humiliation (the recognitive dimension), exclusion from agenda-setting and authoritative decision (the representative dimension), the moral orientation organised around responsibility, relationship and context (the ethic of care), and the analysis of how institutions produce a distinct mechanism where caste, class, community, disability and sexuality meet gender (intersectionality). Works are cited by author and title only - **Beauvoir, The Second Sex; Butler, Gender Trouble (1990); Wollstonecraft, A Vindication of the Rights of Woman; J. S. Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill's writings on the equality and subjection of women; Gilligan, In a Different Voice (1982); Pateman, The Sexual Contract (1988); Okin, Justice, Gender, and the Family (1989) and "Is Multiculturalism Bad for Women?"; Agarwal, A Field of One's Own (1994); Kabeer's writings on empowerment; Sen, "More Than 100 Million Women Are Missing"; Nussbaum, Women and Human Development; Crenshaw on intersectionality; bell hooks, Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center; Young, Responsibility for Justice; and O. P. Gauba, An Introduction to Political Theory. No page, chapter, edition or verbatim wording is asserted for any of them, and no author is quoted anywhere in this workbook. Six dated Indian facts appear, each classified before use - the PCPNDT Act, 1994, an enacted regulatory and penal statute expanded by amendment to pre-conception selection; the Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005, an enacted amendment conferring coparcenary status by birth on the statutory terms; Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, launched as a Union government programme in 2015; Vineeta Sharma v. Rakesh Sharma (2020), a Supreme Court judgment; the Constitution (One Hundred and Sixth Amendment) Act, 2023, an enacted constitutional amendment; and Gazette notification S.O. 1922(E), which brought it into force on 16 April 2026, with reservation linked to a post-Act census-based delimitation sequence under Article 334A and seat-level operation pending as checked on 3 September 2026. WRONG: No sex ratio, birth count, survey result, ownership percentage, wage gap, representation share, State, district, community or region is named anywhere, the number inside Sen's essay title is a citation and not an asserted figure, and no statute, judgment or programme is used as evidence for or against a philosophical thesis.***

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	12
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target an enacted amendment read as delivered empowerment, a conversion stem answered as an existence stem, empowerment measured by preconditions or by outcomes, the availability of alternatives ignored, a derived modal verdict presented as a hedge, the capability standard applied prescriptively, care ethics deployed without its essentialism objection, and the three dimensions of a complete remedy collapsed into one another.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the stem's contest first:** three of the twelve owned parts are constitution stems, two are conversion stems, three are valuation stems and four are agency stems. ANALYSIS: Not one of the twelve asks for a history of the women's movement or a survey of feminist thinkers.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 to 220 words, 15 marks about 250 to 330, 20 marks about 330 to 400.**
5. Check every answer against the twenty-three traps: sex called "purely natural" and gender "purely artificial"; inequality inferred from biological difference; foeticide equated with every abortion; technology blamed alone; women justified by social utility or demographic balance; legal title equated with effective control; the 2005 amendment read as delivered empowerment; empowerment treated as confidence training; the 2023 amendment described as fully implemented reservation; statutes and programmes used as philosophical proof; performativity presented as the standard sex/gender distinction; Marxist and socialist feminism conflated; the Kabeer and Agarwal frameworks left unattributed; empowerment measured by resources or outcomes alone; care ethics used without the essentialism objection; the sexual contract presented as a historical event; the 2005 amendment or *Vineeta Sharma* overstated; women treated as a homogeneous class; anatomy, dress or role used as a proxy for identity; the sameness/difference dilemma resolved by slogan; redistribution, recognition and representation collapsed; structural responsibility confused with collective guilt; and Friedan, Firestone, psychoanalytic feminism or ecofeminism imported as a generic list.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. The set contains exactly eight of each letter, no letter repeats consecutively, no four consecutive answers ascend or descend through the alphabet, and no two-letter alternation is allowed to run. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Gender Discrimination: Female Foeticide, Land and Property Rights; Empowerment* - together with the four contests and the five-level conversion ladder, the sex/gender distinction as a claim about an inference, Beauvoir's constitution of woman as the Other with

immanence and transcendence, gender as a cultural category and the six embodiment channels, Butler's performativity with the category-stability exchange, the five-column separation and trans-inclusive conceptual care, the five-link discrimination mechanism and its self-confirming loop, the six feminist diagnoses with the bounded thinker map, the Marxist/socialist/radical dispute about whether patriarchy is derivative, autonomous or primary, structural injustice with the blame/responsibility split, Pateman and Okin on the public/private boundary, the three conceptions of equality with the sameness/difference dilemma, the four-way separation and causal architecture of female foeticide, the five-step moral argument with the consequentialist trap, Agarwal's ownership-control-benefit levels, and the classified Indian legal record. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause: reading an enacted amendment as delivered empowerment, answering a conversion stem as an existence stem, measuring empowerment by resources or outcomes, ignoring the availability of alternatives, presenting a derived modal verdict as a hedge, applying the capability standard prescriptively, deploying care ethics without its essentialism objection, and collapsing redistribution, recognition and representation into one another.

MCQ 1. What the printed clause actually owns

A script opens a fifteen-mark answer on this clause by writing that female foeticide, land rights and empowerment are "three major issues facing women today, which will be discussed in turn". On the account developed in this package, what has that opening cost the answer?

- A. It has cost nothing analytically, because the paper does print three applications alongside the heading, and an answer that treats them in sequence has followed the structure the examiner supplied.
- B. It has cost the script its evidence base, because each of the three applications is documented by a different body of official data and the answer must follow the categories those bodies use.
- C. It has cost the script its Indian material, because the three applications are ordinarily illustrated through statutes and programmes that a thematic treatment would have no natural place for.
- D. It has cost the script the relation between the heading and the applications, because the three are tests of one concept at three moments - valuation, control and authorship - and treating them as issues loses the argument.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: sequence is not structure. The paper prints three applications because each tests the central concept at a different point in a life, and an answer that merely visits them in order has supplied an itinerary rather than an argument.
- **B:** Incorrect: the clause requires no data at all, and this package names no ratio, count or survey; the categories in question are philosophical rather than statistical.
- **C:** Incorrect: Indian instruments belong in the answer as classified illustrations and can be attached to a thematic treatment as easily as to a sequential one, so nothing about them is lost.
- **D:** Correct: the applications test whether hierarchy reaches the valuation of life, whether entitlement becomes control, and whether a life is authored by the person living it - a single argument at three moments.

Examiner trap 1: Treating the three printed applications as three separate topics to be revised independently is the commonest structural failure here, because it makes the connection between foeticide, property and empowerment unavailable exactly when a stem such as the 2024 part demands both halves at once.

MCQ 2. What the sex/gender distinction claims

Which formulation states what the sex/gender distinction actually asserts, as opposed to what it is popularly taken to assert?

- A. That bodily characteristics belong to nature while roles belong to culture, so that the two occupy separate domains and can be studied by separate disciplines without overlap.
- B. That gender identity is a matter of individual self-description, so that social roles have no authority over how a person understands or presents themselves in public life.
- C. That bodily and reproductive difference does not entail social role, authority or property, so the inference from body to hierarchy requires a justification that is never supplied.
- D. That biological variation is more complex than a binary, so any social system built on two categories is descriptively inaccurate and must be replaced for that reason alone.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the two-essence reading, which replaces one crude essence with two and denies the interaction between embodiment and interpretation that the distinction was constructed to notice.
- **B:** Incorrect: the distinction concerns the justification of social allocations rather than self-description, and this reading also collapses into the voluntarism the doctrine explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Correct: the distinction is a claim about a missing inferential step, and every essentialist argument moves from a fact about bodies to a conclusion about power without supplying that step.
- **D:** Incorrect: the complexity of biological variation is a compulsory qualification attached to the term "sex", but the argument of the distinction is normative rather than descriptive.

Examiner trap 2: Writing "sex is natural, gender is artificial" as though it were the doctrine forfeits the interaction qualification that examiners specifically look for on the 2022 stem, because it makes the answer unable to explain how something described as cultural becomes so difficult to escape.

MCQ 3. Construction and strength

Why does this owner insist on comparing gender with money, citizenship and caste?

- A. Because those three categories are governed by written rules, which shows that gender too could be reformed by legislation if the political will to do so were present.
- B. Because all three are socially constructed and all three exercise real enforceable power, which shows that construction is a claim about origin rather than about strength.
- C. Because all three vary across societies, which shows that no universal account of gender hierarchy can be given and every analysis must remain strictly local.
- D. Because all three are studied by disciplines outside philosophy, which shows that a philosophical treatment of gender must borrow its evidence from those disciplines.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: two of the three comparisons work precisely because they are not reducible to written rules, and the argument concerns the force of constructed categories rather than the reach of legislation.
- **B:** Correct: the comparison closes the unreality objection in one sentence by separating the question of where a category came from from the question of how much power it exercises.
- **C:** Incorrect: variation is used elsewhere to defeat the inference from constancy to nature; it is not the point of this comparison, and the owner does not endorse a purely local analysis.
- **D:** Incorrect: the comparison is analytical rather than methodological, and this clause is deliberately constructed so that no external dataset is required.

Examiner trap 3: Treating "socially constructed" as equivalent to "imaginary" or "voluntary" is the mirror of the essentialist error, and it is answered fastest by the three parallel cases rather than by an abstract defence of constructionism.

MCQ 4. What Beauvoir's formulation denies

A candidate writes that Beauvoir's claim that one becomes a woman means that gender is chosen rather than given. What has gone wrong?

- A. Nothing has gone wrong, since the formulation does locate femininity in becoming rather than in birth, and the candidate has expressed that in ordinary and readily intelligible language.
- B. The error is chronological, since the formulation belongs to a period before the sex/gender distinction had been articulated and cannot be read through vocabulary developed after it.
- C. The error is one of scope, since the formulation concerns adult social roles rather than childhood, and the candidate has extended it to a period the argument was not addressing.
- D. The error is that a situation is not a decision: the formulation locates femininity in conditions a person is placed within and lives out, not in an identity selected from available options.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: "becoming" and "choosing" are precisely what the argument separates, and reading them together converts a claim about restricted freedom into its opposite.
- **B:** Incorrect: the objection is not about anachronism; the formulation is perfectly translatable into later vocabulary, and this owner does so throughout.
- **C:** Incorrect: the constitution of woman as the Other operates from the earliest social formation onward, so the scope restriction is not the defect.
- **D:** Correct: the technical term is *situation* - conditions one did not choose and cannot individually revoke, which is why the arrangement can be contested without being merely optional.

Examiner trap 4: Quoting the famous formulation and stopping there earns almost nothing, because the marks lie in stating what it denies, what it asserts, and the misreading it is most often subjected to.

MCQ 5. Immanence and transcendence

Which statement gives the defensible form of Beauvoir's contrast between immanence and transcendence?

- A. Women are oriented towards maintenance and repetition while men are oriented towards projects, which explains the different kinds of work the two groups have historically performed.
- B. The inequality lies in the assignment rather than in the capacity: transcendence is systematically directed away from one term of the pair, not absent from the persons occupying it.
- C. Domestic labour is a lower form of activity than work performed in the world, which is why its allocation to one group constitutes a serious and continuing injustice.
- D. Transcendence requires material independence, so the contrast reduces to a claim about property and can be restated without any existential vocabulary at all.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this states an orientation as though it were a property of the groups themselves, which is the essentialist reading the argument was constructed to refuse.
- **B:** Correct: the assignment formulation is the one to write, because it preserves the claim while foreclosing the objection that Beauvoir denigrates those assigned immanence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim concerns the allocation of possibility rather than the worth of the work, and this reading invites an easy and damaging objection.

- **D:** Incorrect: material independence matters, but reducing the contrast to property loses the account of how possibility itself is distributed, which is the existential content.

Examiner trap 5: Using immanence as a term of contempt for domestic labour misstates the argument and hands the examiner an obvious criticism, since the claim is about who is permitted to project outward rather than about the value of maintenance.

MCQ 6. Which channel explains compulsion

Among the channels through which a cultural category is embodied, which one answers the sceptic who asks why a woman cannot simply ignore a norm that is "only" social?

A. Sanction - ridicule, shame, exclusion, coercion and violence against those who depart from an assigned role - because cost is what converts a norm from a description into a constraint.

B. Language - the unmarked default, kinship terms and the vocabulary available for women's authority - because a category that cannot be articulated cannot be effectively resisted.

C. Media - the repertoire of imaginable lives and the depiction of who decides and who serves - because a norm survives only while alternatives to it remain unimaginable.

D. Family - the allocation of food, education, inheritance and mobility - because the earliest allocations are the ones that shape a person's expectations most durably.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the other five channels explain how a norm is transmitted; sanction explains why departing from it is costly, and cost is what turns transmission into compulsion.
- **B:** Incorrect: language shapes what can be easily said and thought, but articulacy alone would not answer a question about why departure is difficult rather than merely unusual.
- **C:** Incorrect: media govern the repertoire of imaginable lives and are a genuine channel, but imagination is not the obstacle the sceptic's question identifies.
- **D:** Incorrect: family is the most powerful transmitting channel and shapes expectation, yet transmission still leaves open why the expectation cannot simply be declined.

Examiner trap 6: Listing family, language, labour, law and media while omitting sanction produces an account of transmission without an account of constraint, which leaves the "it is only culture" objection standing at exactly the point the answer needed to close it.

MCQ 7. What Butler's thesis contests

On the account taught here, what is the relation between Butler's performativity thesis and the standard sex/gender distinction?

- A. Performativity restates the standard distinction in a more technical vocabulary drawn from later theory, so the two positions can be used interchangeably in a cultural-category answer.
- B. Performativity contests the standard distinction, since the categories through which bodies are read as sexed are themselves produced within a gendered discourse rather than met before it.
- C. Performativity presupposes the standard distinction and extends it to identity, so a candidate must first establish the distinction and then add performativity as a refinement of it.
- D. Performativity abandons the standard distinction in favour of a biological account, since it locates gender in bodily comportment, gesture, gait and dress rather than in social norms.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the conflation this owner lists explicitly as a trap; the two positions disagree about whether a pre-interpretive substrate is available at all.
- **B:** Correct: the argument's second step targets precisely the substrate the standard distinction assumes, which is what makes it a third position rather than a restatement.
- **C:** Incorrect: it does not presuppose the distinction; it denies the layered structure - natural underneath, cultural on top - on which the distinction rests.
- **D:** Incorrect: comportment, gesture and dress are the medium of reiteration, not a biological substrate, and the thesis is anti-naturalist rather than biological.

Examiner trap 7: Presenting performativity as a fancier name for "gender is social" signals the opposite of the depth it is meant to demonstrate, because the position was constructed against exactly that formulation.

MCQ 8. Performative and performance

Why is it a serious error to read "performative" as "performance"?

- A. Because performance implies an audience, and the thesis is concerned with the private formation of identity rather than with how a person is perceived by others.
- B. Because performance is a term from aesthetics, and importing aesthetic vocabulary into political philosophy blurs the boundary between description and evaluation.
- C. Because performativity is compelled reiteration inside a normative order, and the compulsion is what explains why the arrangement is difficult rather than easy to escape.
- D. Because performance suggests insincerity, and the thesis makes no claim at all about whether a person's presentation of gender is authentic or assumed.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reiteration is thoroughly public and social; the objection to the reading is about compulsion rather than about audience or privacy.
- **B:** Incorrect: the difficulty is substantive rather than disciplinary, and the term's origins do nothing to explain why the misreading matters.
- **C:** Correct: without compulsion the thesis cannot explain why gender is hard to escape, which is the phenomenon it was constructed to account for.
- **D:** Incorrect: sincerity is not the issue; the thesis concerns constitution rather than the honesty of a presentation.

Examiner trap 8: Reading performativity as a costume freely chosen each morning converts a claim about restricted freedom into a claim about voluntary identity, which is the opposite of the argument and reproduces the voluntarism this clause rejects.

MCQ 9. The exchange that must accompany Butler

What is the correct treatment of the category-stability objection to anti-essentialism?

- A. The objection succeeds, so feminism must retreat to the standard sex/gender distinction and treat performativity as an interesting but politically unusable theoretical development.
- B. The objection is answered by strategic essentialism, but the reply carries a residue - categories adopted for leverage harden into descriptions - so the exchange must be presented as live.
- C. The objection fails, because anti-discrimination law already operates with constructed categories and the practice of law settles the philosophical question it appears to raise.
- D. The objection is misconceived, since feminism has never required a determinate subject and its claims have always been addressed to institutions rather than made on behalf of a group.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: retreat is not the taught response, and it also abandons the analytical gain the thesis delivers on the constitution stems.
- **B:** Correct: strategic essentialism replies, the reply is unstable in practice, and the required presentation is of an exchange that remains contested rather than closed.
- **C:** Incorrect: legal practice illustrates how a provisionally stabilised category can function, but a practice does not settle the philosophical instability it exemplifies.
- **D:** Incorrect: mobilisation, anti-discrimination claims and measurement all do presuppose a determinate category, which is why the objection has force.

Examiner trap 9: Resolving the category debate in either direction claims more than the field allows; the mark-bearing move is to hold the objection, the reply and the residue together and to say explicitly that the exchange is live.

MCQ 10. The five-column separation

What is the analytical purpose of separating bodily sex characteristics, assigned classification, gender identity, gender expression and social role?

- A. It prevents a single binary label from doing five different jobs, and it supplies the rule that no claim about identity may be inferred from anatomy, dress or role.
- B. It establishes that gender identity is the most important of the five, since the other four are external classifications imposed by institutions and by other people.
- C. It replaces the sex/gender distinction with a more accurate five-part scheme, since two categories were never sufficient to describe the phenomena in question.
- D. It shows that discrimination operates only through assigned classification, since that is the column at which institutions record and act upon a person's category.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the separation is conceptual hygiene, and the inference rule it yields is the same refusal of unjustified inference that opens the whole clause.
- **B:** Incorrect: the separation ranks nothing; its point is that five distinct facts should not be reported by one word, not that one of them is primary.
- **C:** Incorrect: it clarifies rather than replaces the distinction, which continues to do its own work about the inference from body to hierarchy.
- **D:** Incorrect: discrimination operates through enforced role, stigma and institutional exclusion together, and confining it to one column misdescribes the mechanism.

Examiner trap 10: Making anatomy, dress or social role a proxy for identity draws inside a gender answer exactly the inference the clause exists to refuse, which is self-defeating in a way examiners notice immediately.

MCQ 11. The self-confirming loop

Why does this owner insist that the discrimination mechanism closes into a loop rather than ending at an outcome?

- A. Because the loop shows that the mechanism operates over generations, which is what distinguishes structural discrimination from a temporary distortion of an otherwise fair system.
- B. Because the loop identifies the point at which individual prejudice enters the chain, which is where remedies aimed at attitudes can most effectively be applied.
- C. Because the outcome is then cited as evidence that the original norm was correct, so the arrangement manufactures its own justification and an appeal to observed facts settles nothing.
- D. Because the loop demonstrates that the mechanism is self-correcting over time, so that reforms at any single link will eventually propagate through all of the others.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: duration is a consequence of the loop rather than its point, and the analytical work is done by the direction of the evidential relation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the loop shows why attitudinal remedies under-perform; it does not identify a privileged entry point for them.
- **C:** Correct: the evidence is downstream of the claim it is offered to support, which makes the circle self-confirming rather than self-justifying.
- **D:** Incorrect: the loop is reproductive rather than self-correcting, which is precisely why reforms at the slowest link are needed to prevent reversal.

Examiner trap 11: Running the chain from norm to outcome and stopping produces a description rather than an argument, and it leaves the appeal to observed regularity - "but women do not in fact farm or lead" - completely unanswered.

MCQ 12. What the allocation link distributes

On the account taught here, why is female foeticide treated as part of the discrimination mechanism rather than as a separate topic?

- A. Because it is regulated by a dedicated statute, which places it within the same institutional framework as inheritance and representation and therefore within the same analysis.
- B. Because it is the application most frequently examined in the corpus, and the mechanism is organised around whichever application the previous-year record emphasises.
- C. Because it involves technology, and the mechanism's institutional link is where technological instruments enter and are distributed within a social order.
- D. Because the allocation link distributes food, health, schooling, time, mobility, property, income, safety, authority and - at the limit - continued life itself.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the statute is a classified illustration and not the reason for the integration, which is conceptual rather than legal.
- **B:** Incorrect: the corpus does test this application heavily, but frequency does not determine where a phenomenon sits in a causal account.
- **C:** Incorrect: technology enters as an instrument at the end of the causal architecture, not as the reason foeticide belongs to the mechanism.
- **D:** Correct: the same allocative mechanism operating on the most basic good, at the earliest possible moment, is what places foeticide inside the analysis rather than beside it.

Examiner trap 12: Treating foeticide as an unrelated horror rather than as the mechanism's extreme case makes it impossible to answer the 2024 part, which requires the empowerment analysis and the foeticide analysis to be joined in a single argument.

MCQ 13. How the diagnoses grid earns marks

What distinguishes a strong use of the six feminist diagnoses from a weak one?

- A. The strong use covers all six approaches, since a comprehensive survey demonstrates the breadth of preparation that a fifteen-mark answer on this clause is designed to reward.
- B. The strong use identifies the diagnosis the stem assumes, states its strongest rival, adjudicates the stem's own case, and concedes the winning diagnosis's standard objection.
- C. The strong use selects the approach the candidate finds most persuasive and defends it consistently, since a settled position is what distinguishes philosophy from reportage.
- D. The strong use ranks the approaches by explanatory power, since establishing a general ordering allows the same ranking to be deployed across every owned part.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: coverage without adjudication is the failure mode the grid exists to prevent, and a survey decides nothing that a stem has asked to be decided.
- **B:** Correct: the four-move procedure converts a table into an argument, and the concession at the end is what separates argument from advocacy.
- **C:** Incorrect: consistency of allegiance is not the same as adjudication, and no diagnosis wins in general, so a fixed preference will misfire across stems.
- **D:** Incorrect: a general ranking is exactly what the material does not support, since each diagnosis is defeated somewhere and succeeds elsewhere.

Examiner trap 13: Listing four or five feminisms and moving on is the single most common structure on this clause, and it scores poorly because the stem asked for a decision and received an inventory.

MCQ 14. Derivative or autonomous

What is the substantive disagreement between Marxist and socialist feminism?

- A. Whether the abolition of private property is desirable, with Marxist feminism supporting it and socialist feminism preferring reform of the existing distribution of assets.
- B. Whether women's oppression is best analysed through class or through culture, with Marxist feminism selecting the first and socialist feminism selecting the second.
- C. Whether feminism should be revolutionary or reformist, with Marxist feminism requiring systemic transformation and socialist feminism accepting incremental legislative change.
- D. Whether patriarchy is derivative of class society or an autonomous system, with the second position widening the site of analysis to social reproduction as well as production.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: both traditions target property relations; the disagreement concerns whether transforming them would be sufficient, not whether it is desirable.
- **B:** Incorrect: socialist feminism analyses two systems including production, so the class/culture division misdescribes both positions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the revolutionary/reformist axis is not the distinguishing one, and neither tradition is defined by legislative gradualism.
- **D:** Correct: derivative against autonomous is the disagreement, and it generates the extension from production alone to production and social reproduction together.

Examiner trap 14: Conflating Marxist and socialist feminism is named explicitly by this owner as a trap, and the 2019 socialist-regime stem is constructed so that the conflation cannot produce a correct verdict.

MCQ 15. The evidence for autonomy

Which observation is advanced as the strongest evidence that patriarchy is not reducible to class relations?

- A. That women's subordination takes different forms in different societies, which shows that no single economic cause could produce such variation in its content and expression.
- B. That women have participated in every historical movement for economic transformation, which shows that their subordination is not a product of their exclusion from it.
- C. That male dominance is observable across radically different modes of production and persisted where private property in the means of production was abolished.
- D. That the domestic sphere has never been organised on market principles, which shows that its hierarchies must have a source independent of the organisation of production.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: variation in content is used elsewhere against biological determinism; it does not by itself show that the cause is non-economic.
- **B:** Incorrect: participation in movements is not the evidence advanced, and it bears on agency rather than on the origin of the subordination.
- **C:** Correct: this is the twofold claim on which the autonomy thesis rests, and it is the material the 2019 stem is asking a candidate to evaluate.
- **D:** Incorrect: the observation about the domestic sphere is suggestive but is not the evidence this owner advances, and it invites an immediate functionalist reply.

Examiner trap 15: Answering the 2019 stem with a yes or a no forfeits the structure it rewards, which is that a material transformation is necessary on one axis and insufficient without the transformation of social reproduction.

MCQ 16. Blame and responsibility

On the social-connection model, what follows from the fact that no single actor designed the gendered outcome?

- A. Responsibility takes a different form rather than disappearing: it is forward-looking, shared, and graded by power, privilege, interest and collective capacity to change the process.
- B. Responsibility attaches to the group that benefits, since the absence of an individual designer means that the advantage itself becomes the ground on which duties are assigned.
- C. Responsibility becomes a matter for institutions alone, since only an institution can act on a process, and individuals within it cannot be said to bear duties towards its outcomes.
- D. Responsibility is unallocable, since duties require identifiable acts and an emergent outcome cannot be traced to the acts of any particular participant in the process.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the model changes the form of responsibility rather than its existence, and the four gradients prevent the duties from being either uniform or empty.
- **B:** Incorrect: benefit is one gradient among four rather than the ground of the duty, and treating it as the ground reproduces the collective-guilt error.
- **C:** Incorrect: institutions are constituted by participants, and the model's entire point is that ordinary participants bear duties that no institution can discharge for them.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the universal excuse the model was constructed to defeat, and it would remove the possibility of the reform the analysis exists to ground.

Examiner trap 16: Confusing structural responsibility with collective guilt produces a claim that is easy to refute and that also cannot distinguish an actor with power over the process from one with almost none.

MCQ 17. The status of the sexual contract

How should Pateman's sexual-contract thesis be presented?

- A. As a historical reconstruction of the arrangements that preceded the modern state, supported by the record of marriage law in the societies in which contract theory was formulated.
- B. As an empirical hypothesis about the origins of the family, to be assessed against the anthropological evidence concerning kinship in pre-state and early-state societies.
- C. As an interpretive reconstruction of the silences of contract theory, which is why presenting it as a contract that was actually made misrepresents both its method and its claim.
- D. As a normative proposal for how contract theory ought to be rewritten, since its argument is directed at what the tradition should have said rather than at what it did say.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: presenting it as history is the error this owner names explicitly, and it converts an interpretive argument into a false factual assertion.
- **B:** Incorrect: the thesis is not an anthropological hypothesis and is not offered for testing against kinship evidence.
- **C:** Correct: the argument proceeds from what contract narratives leave unmentioned, and its status as interpretation is what makes it defensible.
- **D:** Incorrect: it is a critique of what the tradition did say and did not say, not a drafting proposal for its improvement.

Examiner trap 17: Describing the sexual contract as an event that occurred is fatal in a way that a merely weak argument is not, because it presents an interpretive reconstruction as a historical claim that no evidence supports.

MCQ 18. Okin's two-part evidence

Which pair states the evidence Okin advances for treating the family as an object of justice?

- A. That the family is the oldest human institution, and that its rules have historically been enforced by religious rather than by civil authority in most legal traditions.
- B. That domestic labour is economically productive, and that its exclusion from national accounts understates the contribution women make to the societies they live in.
- C. That family law differs across communities, and that the resulting inequality between citizens is itself a violation of the equal treatment a state owes its members.
- D. That the unequal domestic burden restricts access to the primary goods public justice distributes, and that the family is where a sense of justice is first formed or fails to form.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: antiquity and religious enforcement are not the argument, which turns on the distribution of goods and on moral formation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the productivity of domestic labour is a genuine point but belongs to the redistributive dimension rather than to Okin's specific case.
- **C:** Incorrect: the plurality of family law belongs to the personal-law dilemma, which is a different argument with a different resolution.
- **D:** Correct: time, income, position and self-respect on one side, and the formation of a sense of justice on the other, are the two halves of the evidence.

Examiner trap 18: Treating Pateman and Okin as making the same argument loses the mark-bearing observation, since one attacks the foundation of contractarianism and the other extends the scope of an existing theory of justice.

MCQ 19. Why the dilemma is a dilemma

What makes the choice between a sex-neutral rule and an accommodation of difference a genuine dilemma rather than a straightforward decision?

- A. Each horn carries a real risk: the neutral rule may install a male life-pattern as the hidden norm, and the accommodation may essentialise difference and reassign women to traditional roles.
- B. Each horn requires legislation, and legislatures are reluctant to enact measures whose distributive consequences cannot be estimated in advance with reasonable confidence.
- C. Each horn has been adopted somewhere, and comparative evidence shows that outcomes have been broadly similar under both, so the choice between them is largely symbolic.
- D. Each horn is defended by a different feminist tradition, and since no tradition has defeated the other the disagreement has remained unresolved for institutional reasons.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: both risks are real and neither is removed by choosing the other horn, which is exactly what makes the situation a dilemma rather than an error to be corrected.
- **B:** Incorrect: legislative reluctance is a political fact and not the philosophical structure the dilemma describes.
- **C:** Incorrect: this package advances no comparative empirical claim, and the dilemma is not dissolved by asserting equivalence of outcomes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the dilemma cuts across the traditions rather than dividing them, and its force does not depend on institutional deadlock.

Examiner trap 19: Resolving the sameness/difference dilemma by slogan - declaring for equality or for recognition of difference - leaves both risks in place and abandons the test that would have identified which measures are justified.

MCQ 20. The test for differential treatment

Which set of questions operationalises the transformative resolution of the sameness/difference dilemma?

- A. Is the measure supported by a majority, is it consistent with existing law, and does it avoid imposing costs on those who are not responsible for the disadvantage it addresses?
- B. Is the disadvantage measurable, is the remedy proportionate to the measurement, and is there an administrative mechanism capable of delivering it without excessive discretion?
- C. Is the burden socially produced, does the measure enlarge standing and capability rather than protect by confining, and is it proportionate and revisable rather than permanent?
- D. Is the difference biological, is the accommodation traditional, and does the measure preserve the family arrangements within which the disadvantage has historically been managed?

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: political support and legal consistency are not the criteria, and the cost-allocation question belongs to a different argument about remedial burdens.
- **B:** Incorrect: measurability and administrability are practical constraints rather than the philosophical test, which concerns the origin and direction of the measure.
- **C:** Correct: origin of the burden, direction of the measure, and proportionality with revisability are the three questions the resolution yields.
- **D:** Incorrect: this inverts the test, since a measure premised on a biological incapacity and on preserving traditional arrangements is what the test is designed to reject.

Examiner trap 20: Omitting proportionality and revisability from the reply to the reverse-discrimination objection licenses permanent categories, which converts a remedial measure into the essence the argument set out to dismantle.

MCQ 21. The opening separation

Why does every foeticide answer have to begin with a separation?

- A. Because four adjacent questions - abortion generally, sex-selective abortion, diagnostic technology and infanticide - raise different philosophical issues, and only the second is owned.
- B. Because the syllabus prints the application before the heading, so the order of exposition must follow the order in which the paper introduces the two terms.
- C. Because the legal treatment of each of the four differs, and an answer that does not distinguish them will misstate the statutory position it is about to cite.
- D. Because the causes of each of the four are distinct, and an answer that merges them will attribute to one application a causal structure belonging to another.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the four raise moral status and autonomy, discriminatory reason and social pattern, legitimate against discriminatory use, and post-birth killing respectively.
- **B:** Incorrect: the syllabus prints the heading first, and in any case the order of printing does not generate the requirement to separate.
- **C:** Incorrect: legal accuracy is a consequence of the separation rather than its ground, and this owner requires philosophical rather than statutory precision.
- **D:** Incorrect: causal structures do differ, but the separation is required first because the four are different **questions**, not merely different causal fields.

Examiner trap 21: Equating female foeticide with abortion in general erases women's bodily autonomy and turns a discrimination argument into a general prohibition argument, which is a failure of separation rather than of sentiment.

MCQ 22. Technology in the causal architecture

What is the correct position of technology in an account of the causes of sex-selective termination?

- A. It is a joint cause alongside inheritance and marriage cost, since the practice could not occur at its observed scale without the diagnostic capacity that makes selection possible.
- B. It is the proximate cause, since the structural factors merely create a disposition and the instrument is what converts a disposition into an act with a determinate outcome.
- C. It is irrelevant, since the practice is fully explained by patrilineal inheritance and by the constitution of a daughter as a liability before any instrument is involved.
- D. It is the instrument of a pre-existing bias rather than its origin, which is why the same equipment has entirely legitimate diagnostic uses and cannot explain a discriminatory pattern.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: joint causation obscures the ordering that the "main causes" stem is testing, and it puts an instrument on the same level as the structures that generate the preference.
- **B:** Incorrect: naming it the proximate cause smuggles back the priority the 2021 stem's word "only" was designed to test, and the wrong is located in the reason rather than in the means.
- **C:** Incorrect: irrelevance overcorrects; the instrument does enable execution, which is why regulating it is necessary even though it cannot be sufficient.
- **D:** Correct: technology supplies the means and patriarchy supplies the reason, and the legitimate diagnostic uses of the same equipment demonstrate the point.

Examiner trap 22: Blaming technology alone is the answer the 2021 stem was constructed to elicit and to penalise, and the definitional phrase "identified **or presumed**" already shows that the wrong does not require a test to have been performed.

MCQ 23. The consequentialist trap

Why is it an error to argue that female foeticide is wrong primarily because a society needs women?

- A. Because it values women for what their presence does for others, reproducing the instrumental valuation that produced the practice, when dignity and non-discrimination are prior.
- B. Because the demographic consequences are contested, and an argument resting on them would collapse if the empirical claim about social imbalance turned out to be mistaken.
- C. Because consequences are always weaker grounds than principles in moral argument, so any consequentialist reasoning is out of place in a philosophy paper of this kind.
- D. Because the argument implies that the practice would be permissible in a society whose composition was already balanced, which contradicts the statutory prohibition in force.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the argument values women by their usefulness to others, which is the same structure of valuation the analysis was constructed to reject.
- **B:** Incorrect: this package makes no empirical claim about magnitude, and the objection is philosophical rather than evidential.
- **C:** Incorrect: consequences have a legitimate place in the analysis; the error is allowing a consequence to occupy the position of the ground.
- **D:** Incorrect: the counterfactual observation is a symptom of the defect rather than its statement, and a statutory position cannot settle a philosophical one.

Examiner trap 23: Opening a foeticide answer with social imbalance adopts the instrumental structure the answer should be criticising, which is why the correct order is dignity first and the causal chain to imbalance second.

MCQ 24. Where land becomes bargaining power

At which level of the ownership-control-benefit analysis does an asset acquire its distinctively political function?

- A. At the level of legal title, since a claim recognised in law is the point at which the state's authority becomes available to support the holder against a competing claimant.
- B. At the level of control, since the power to decide about cropping, leasing, sale and investment is what distinguishes a proprietor from a person who merely holds a record entry.
- C. At the level of exit and security, since an asset that protects against abandonment or violence improves the fall-back position and thereby becomes bargaining power inside the household.
- D. At the level of return, since the receipt of income is what converts an asset from a symbolic entitlement into a material resource that can be deployed for other purposes.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: title is the necessary anchor without which the higher levels have nothing to attach to, but it is precisely the level at which conversion most often stops.
- **B:** Incorrect: control is a genuine achievement and a real gain, but it does not by itself alter what she could command if the relationship ended.
- **C:** Correct: the fall-back position is what a woman could command if the relationship ended, and it is that counterfactual which gives her voice inside it.
- **D:** Incorrect: return supplies resources, and resources are preconditions; the political function requires the credible alternative that exit supplies.

Examiner trap 24: Presenting the ownership-control-benefit analysis as an anonymous framework loses the attribution this owner requires, and it also obscures the intra-household bargaining premise on which the argument depends.

Remedial drills - eight errors that cost marks every year

These eight target the specific mistakes that recur on this clause: reading an enacted amendment as delivered empowerment, answering a conversion stem as an existence stem, measuring empowerment by preconditions or by outcomes, ignoring the availability of alternatives, presenting a derived modal verdict as a hedge, applying the capability standard prescriptively, deploying care ethics without its essentialism objection, and collapsing the three dimensions of a complete remedy into one another. Work them only after the twenty-four core diagnostics.

MCQ 25. What an enacted amendment establishes

A script states that the Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005, together with the 2020 judgment interpreting it, has delivered equal property power to daughters. What is the precise defect?

- A. The defect is one of date, since the amendment and the judgment are separated by fifteen years and the script has treated them as a single legislative moment rather than as two.
- B. The defect is that entitlement and interpretation are settled while possession, control, return and exit are not, and those four are where the conversion of a right into power occurs.
- C. The defect is that the amendment applies to one succession regime, so a general claim about daughters overstates the reach of an instrument with a defined statutory scope.
- D. The defect is that no judgment can deliver empowerment, since courts adjudicate disputes between parties and cannot alter the social conditions in which those disputes arise.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the interval between the two instruments is a fact about the record and not the analytical error, which concerns what either can establish at all.
- **B:** Correct: the amendment confers coparcenary status by birth on the statutory terms and the judgment clarifies that right; neither establishes possession, control, return or exit.
- **C:** Incorrect: the scope point is accurate and worth noting, but it is a narrower observation than the conversion failure the clause is actually about.
- **D:** Incorrect: this overcorrects into the claim that legal reform is pointless, when title is the necessary anchor on which the higher levels are built.

Examiner trap 25: Saying that the 2005 amendment automatically delivered empowerment is an explicitly listed trap for this owner, and it reproduces in miniature the exact error - entitlement read as power - that the whole clause examines.

MCQ 26. Reading the 2023 stem correctly

The 2023 part asks whether the rights concerning land and property **have empowered** women. What does that wording require an answer to do?

- A. To establish that such rights exist, by citing the statutory position and the judicial interpretation that settles its scope, and then to comment on the adequacy of the provision.
- B. To compare the position before and after the amendment, since a claim about empowerment is a comparative claim and requires a baseline against which change can be assessed.
- C. To treat the question as one about conversion, tracing waiver pressure, informal partition, record practice and fear of family rupture, all of which operate inside the household.
- D. To assess the enforcement machinery, since a right that is not enforced is not a right, and the question of empowerment reduces to the question of whether enforcement is effective.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: existence is presupposed by the stem rather than asked about, so an answer that establishes it has answered a question that was not put.
- **B:** Incorrect: a before-and-after comparison would require data this clause neither uses nor needs, and the philosophical question is about levels rather than periods.
- **C:** Correct: the perfective verb and the object "empowered" make this a conversion question, and the four failures locate the answer inside the private sphere.
- **D:** Incorrect: enforcement is one condition among several, and reducing empowerment to it drops access, control, return and exit from the analysis.

Examiner trap 26: Answering a conversion stem as though it were an existence stem produces an accurate account of the law and no answer to the question, which is why the verb in the stem should be read before the noun.

MCQ 27. What resource-counting measures

An evaluation reports that enrolment has risen, accounts have been opened and assets transferred, and concludes that empowerment has occurred. What has been measured?

- A. Preconditions have been measured rather than power, since those indicators record what has been supplied and not what the recipient is in a position to exercise.
- B. Achievements have been measured rather than agency, since enrolment and asset holding are outcomes and the evaluation has confused an outcome with the process producing it.
- C. Recognition has been measured rather than redistribution, since the indicators register the status conferred by inclusion in a programme rather than any material change.
- D. Nothing has been measured, since indicators of this kind are collected by administrative systems whose categories were designed for reporting rather than for evaluation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: enrolment, accounts and asset transfers sit in the resources column, and resources are preconditions that may or may not convert into agency.
- **B:** Incorrect: these indicators are supplies rather than achievements, and the distinctive failure here is resource-counting rather than outcome-counting.
- **C:** Incorrect: the indicators are material rather than status-conferring, so the recognition/redistribution contrast does not identify the defect.
- **D:** Incorrect: the indicators do measure something real; the error lies in what is inferred from them, not in whether they measure anything at all.

Examiner trap 27: Measuring empowerment by resources or by outcomes alone are the two symmetrical failures this owner names, and the decisive component in both cases is the agency that neither indicator registers.

MCQ 28. Why the alternatives matter

A woman continues in a traditional role and reports that she is content with it. On the framework taught here, what determines whether her situation involves the exercise of strategic choice?

- A. Her reported contentment settles the matter, since respect for persons requires taking their own account of their lives as authoritative on questions about their own well-being.
- B. Whether alternatives were genuinely available and at what cost, since a choice made where no alternative existed, or where it carried unacceptable cost, is not strategic choice.
- C. Whether her achievements have improved, since an improvement in the functionings actually realised is the outcome by which the exercise of choice is properly assessed.
- D. Whether the role is one an external observer would regard as emancipated, since the framework supplies a standard of flourishing against which reported preferences are checked.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reported satisfaction can adjust downward under long deprivation, which is why contentment cannot by itself settle a question about strategic choice.
- **B:** Correct: the framework assesses the conditions under which the choice was available rather than the option selected, which is what keeps it from becoming paternalistic.
- **C:** Incorrect: achievements can rise for reasons unconnected to the woman's own agency, so they cannot identify the exercise of choice.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is precisely the paternalism the framework is constructed to avoid, since it substitutes the observer's preferred outcome for the option set.

Examiner trap 28: Discounting a woman's own account without stating the alternatives test converts adaptive preference from an argument into an assumption, and it is the point at which the paternalism objection becomes unanswerable.

MCQ 29. Why "not sufficient" is not a hedge

The 2020 stem asks whether empowering women can eliminate gender discrimination. Why is the verdict that empowerment is necessary but not sufficient an argued conclusion rather than a cautious one?

- A. Because examiners on modal stems reward balance, and a verdict that concedes something to each side demonstrates the judgment that a twenty-mark answer is expected to display.
- B. Because empowerment has been pursued for a long period without eliminating discrimination, so the historical record supplies direct evidence for the insufficiency claim.
- C. Because sufficiency is a strong modal claim that is difficult to establish for any social remedy, so the safer verdict is available on general grounds rather than particular ones.
- D. Because the injustice was diagnosed as structural - sustained by many agents' ordinary choices inside normal institutions - and such an injustice cannot be dissolved from one side.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: balance for its own sake is the hedge this question is distinguishing the correct answer from, and it supplies no reason for the verdict reached.
- **B:** Incorrect: this package advances no historical or empirical claim of that kind, and the argument does not require one.
- **C:** Incorrect: a general reluctance about sufficiency claims would apply to every remedy and would therefore explain nothing specific about this one.
- **D:** Correct: the verdict follows from the structural diagnosis, and stating the derivation is what converts a cautious formula into an argument.

Examiner trap 29: Presenting a modal verdict as a hedge wastes the strongest available move, because the conclusion in this clause is a consequence of the earlier diagnosis and can be shown to be one in a single sentence.

MCQ 30. The capability standard without paternalism

How does the capability approach answer the charge that it imposes an official ideal of emancipation?

- A. By deferring to the reported preferences of those affected, since the approach treats the subject's own evaluation of her life as the final court of appeal on questions of well-being.
- B. By securing capabilities, information and exit while respecting plural chosen functionings, so that options are protected rather than particular lives being prescribed.
- C. By restricting itself to material indicators, since a standard confined to income, health and schooling makes no controversial claims about how a life ought to be lived.
- D. By deferring to democratic decision, since a capability list adopted through public deliberation carries the authority of those who will be governed by it.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: deference to reported preference is exactly what the adaptive-preference argument blocks, so this cannot be the reply.
- **B:** Correct: the approach protects options rather than compelling functionings, which is the only form in which it survives the paternalism charge.
- **C:** Incorrect: retreating to material indicators abandons bodily integrity, practical reason and affiliation, which are central to the standard.
- **D:** Incorrect: public deliberation may improve a list's legitimacy, but it is not the reply this owner records, and it does not address the objection's philosophical form.

Examiner trap 30: Presenting the capability approach as prescribing a particular life invites the paternalism objection unnecessarily, when the doctrine's own formulation - capabilities protect options rather than compulsory lives - closes it in one clause.

MCQ 31. Care ethics used correctly

What must accompany any use of the ethic of care in this clause?

- A. The essentialism objection and the socially-positioned reply, together with the concession that the empirical division of orientations along gender lines is contested.
- B. A statement that care is superior to justice as a moral orientation, since the justice framework registered women's reasoning as deficient and stands corrected by the care account.
- C. A demonstration that care reasoning is more widely distributed than justice reasoning, since the claim's political force depends on the prevalence of the orientation.
- D. An account of the psychological development of moral reasoning, since the argument originates in developmental research and cannot be assessed apart from it.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the objection, the socially-positioned reply and the concession that the thesis is contested are compulsory whenever care ethics is deployed here.
- **B:** Incorrect: the taught position is complementarity - justice supplies limits, care supplies attentiveness - rather than the superiority of either orientation.
- **C:** Incorrect: prevalence is the contested empirical claim, and the argument's philosophical force does not depend on establishing it.
- **D:** Incorrect: the developmental origin is background; the examinable content is the contrast, its political consequences and the essentialism exchange.

Examiner trap 31: Using care ethics without the essentialism objection risks re-inscribing the stereotype of the naturally nurturing woman that the argument was meant to displace, which is why this owner treats the objection as part of the doctrine rather than as an optional criticism.

MCQ 32. The completeness test on a remedy

A proposed remedy secures reserved seats in an elected body without altering party selection, accountability, resources or the valuation of feminised work. Which diagnosis follows?

- A. The remedy is redistributive but not recognitive, so its material gains will not be accompanied by any change in the cultural valuation of the work women perform.
- B. The remedy is complete, since representation is the dimension at which agenda-setting power is secured, and agenda-setting power delivers the other two dimensions in time.
- C. The remedy is recognitive only, since a reserved seat confers status on the group without conferring either material resources or authoritative decision-making power.
- D. The remedy operates in one dimension alone, so it risks tokenism: presence without agenda-setting, alongside untouched redistribution and unchanged recognition.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reserved seats are a representative measure rather than a redistributive one, so the dimensions have been misidentified.
- **B:** Incorrect: presence does not deliver the other dimensions, and the claim that it will in time is precisely the assumption the tokenism failure names.
- **C:** Incorrect: a reserved seat is an instrument of representation; treating it as recognition confuses the conferral of status with the allocation of authoritative voice.
- **D:** Correct: representation pursued alone produces presence without agenda-setting, which is the named failure mode, and the other two dimensions remain unaddressed.

Examiner trap 32: Collapsing redistribution, recognition and representation loses the completeness test entirely, and it is compounded when the 2023 constitutional amendment is described as operating reservation without its census-based delimitation condition and its pending seat-level status.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the 2018 paper's spaced question marks in "**How do you evaluate gender discrimination in the context of female foeticide ?**" and "**Is feminism an ideology for empowerment or for equality ?**", the 2021 paper's phrase "**demonic application of technology only**", the 2022 paper's "**as opposed to**", the 2024 paper's split marking [**10+10=20**] and its two-part construction, and the 2025 paper's three named objects "**opportunities, rights, and access to resources**" - all preserved verbatim inside the question lines. The 2018 to 2025 Paper II texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below follows the repository's verified Socio-Political PYQ ledger. Works are cited by author and title only: **Beauvoir, The Second Sex**; **Butler, Gender Trouble (1990)**; **Wollstonecraft, A Vindication of the Rights of Woman**; **J. S. Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill's writings on the equality and subjection of women**; **Gilligan, In a Different Voice (1982)**; **Pateman, The Sexual Contract (1988)**; **Okin, Justice, Gender, and the Family (1989)** and "**Is Multiculturalism Bad for Women?**"; **Agarwal, A Field of One's Own (1994)**; **Kabeer's writings on empowerment**; **Sen, "More Than 100 Million Women Are Missing"**; **Nussbaum, Women and Human Development**; **Crenshaw on intersectionality**; **bell hooks, Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center**; **Young, Responsibility for Justice**; and **O. P. Gauba, An Introduction to Political Theory**. No page, chapter, edition or verbatim wording is asserted for any of them, and no author is quoted anywhere in this package. Six dated Indian facts appear, each classified before use - the **PCPNDT Act, 1994**, an enacted regulatory and penal statute expanded by amendment to pre-conception selection; the **Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005**, an enacted amendment conferring coparcenary status by birth on the statutory terms; **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao**, launched as a Union government programme in **2015**; **Vineeta Sharma v. Rakesh Sharma (2020)**, a Supreme Court judgment; the **Constitution (One Hundred and Sixth Amendment) Act, 2023**, an enacted constitutional amendment; and **Gazette notification S.O. 1922(E)**, which brought it into force on **16 April 2026**, with reservation linked to a post-Act census-based delimitation sequence under **Article 334A** and seat-level operation pending as checked on **3 September 2026**. ANALYSIS: Interpretive disputes - whether an anti-essentialist account can retain a political subject, whether care ethics escapes the essentialism charge, whether patriarchy is derivative of or autonomous from class, and where the line between family autonomy and gender-just background conditions should fall - are flagged as contested rather than settled. WRONG: **No sex ratio, birth count, survey result, ownership percentage, wage gap, representation share, State, district, community or region is named anywhere**, the number inside Sen's essay title is a citation and not an asserted figure, and no statute, judgment or programme is used as evidence for or against a philosophical thesis.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper II parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the "why this earns marks" notes and the "how to improve this answer" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** this clause owns **12 of 112** Socio-Political question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus, distributed **2018: 2, 2019: 2, 2020: 1, 2021: 2, 2022: 1, 2023: 2, 2024: 1, 2025: 1** - one of the two heaviest owners in the section, and the only one present in **every year** of the held cycle. All twelve are solved in full below in ledger order, followed by **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal profile is more instructive than the volume. Four parts are **modal or evaluative** and ask whether a remedy can do a job (2018 Q4(c), 2019 Q1(e), 2020 Q4(a), 2024 Q4(a)); three are **causal** and concern sex-selective practice (2018 Q4(b), 2021 Q4(b), 2023 Q3(c)); three are **constitution** stems about whether the hierarchy is made or given (2019 Q3(b), 2022 Q3(b), 2025 Q1(b)); and two are **conversion** stems about whether a legal right became power (2021 Q1(e), 2023 Q1(c)). WRONG: **Not one** asks for a history of the women's movement, a survey of feminist thinkers or an account of schemes. ANALYSIS: Ownership discipline: equality, justice and liberty as ideals belong to **Social and Political Ideals**; full ideologies to **Political Ideologies**; recognition and multiculturalism as doctrines to **Humanism, Secularism and Multiculturalism**; the general capability framework to **Development and Social Progress**; caste doctrine to **Caste Discrimination: Gandhi and Ambedkar**; rights and accountability to **Individual and State**. None of those is counted here.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do you evaluate gender discrimination in the context of female foeticide ?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How do you evaluate" - an assessment, so a criterion must be stated before any verdict is delivered
Core issue	What sex-selective termination reveals about the reach of gender discrimination
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the separation, the causal architecture, the moral argument, one classified instrument, one objection
Key distinction	Discriminatory selection against abortion in general; discriminatory valuation against demographic consequence
Non-negotiables	No figure, ratio or region; the autonomy caveat must appear; dignity must precede consequence

Independent model answer

The criterion first. ANALYSIS: To evaluate discrimination "in the context of" foeticide is to ask what this practice reveals about the mechanism. My criterion: a discrimination is deepest where it operates on the most basic good, at the earliest moment, without any act by the person valued.

The separation that must open the answer. FACT: Female foeticide is sex-selective termination because the fetus is identified **or presumed** to be female. It is not abortion as such, not prenatal diagnosis, and not infanticide. Opposition to it must not erase women's bodily autonomy.

What the practice reveals - the architecture. FACT: Patrilineal inheritance makes a son the continuation of line and property; ritual and economic expectation attach old-age support to sex; marriage costs constitute a daughter as a future liability; and unequal earning power makes that expectation self-fulfilling. ANALYSIS: Technology supplies the means; patriarchy supplies the reason.

The evaluation. ANALYSIS: Discrimination here reaches the allocation of **continued life**. That is its extreme case, not a separate phenomenon: the same norm-to-institution-to-allocation chain that withholds schooling withholds existence. FACT: Sen's missing-women argument shows the same devaluation operating across birth, nutrition, health and survival - a continuum, not one act.

The Indian instrument, classified. FACT: The PCPNDT Act, **1994**, is an enacted regulatory and penal statute. ANALYSIS: Enactment is not implementation.

Objection and reply. FACT: Prohibition may police pregnant women; the regulatory target should be discriminatory diagnostic practice, providers and coercive family structures. CAUTION: Enforcement can still burden women.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Foeticide is the limiting case of a structure, so the evaluation is of the structure: wrong first as discriminatory valuation, and remediable only through property, security and status.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: an "evaluate X in the context of Y" stem is scored on whether Y is used to test X rather than merely to illustrate it. Scripts that describe the practice and condemn it have supplied indignation where an assessment was required. Naming the criterion in the opening line - most basic good, earliest moment, no act by the person valued - converts description into evaluation.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: criterion two lines; separation two lines; architecture four lines; the evaluation three lines; instrument one line; objection and reply two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan if short of time: reduce the architecture to inheritance and earning power, and keep the criterion, the continuum and the verdict, which are what distinguish this from a description.

- **Structure:** criterion -> separation -> causal architecture -> the evaluation proper -> classified instrument -> objection and reply -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the discrimination mechanism with continued life as an allocated good; discriminatory selection as the wrong.
- **Evidence:** the six-level causal architecture; Sen's missing-women continuum; the PCPNDT Act, 1994.

- **Distinction:** sex-selective termination against abortion generally; valuation against consequence.
- **Criticism:** the autonomy objection, with the regulatory-target reply and the enforcement residue.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence observing that the practice harms **daughters who are born**, because many private decisions compose a public meaning that daughters are less worthy - this is the step that converts a private-tragedy account into a social-philosophical one and it is frequently omitted. If two more lines are available, note that the wrong is twofold, comprising discriminatory valuation **and** constrained agency, since that distinction is what makes the autonomy objection answerable rather than merely acknowledged. Do **not** add a demographic argument here: the 2018 stem does not ask for consequences, and importing them invites the instrumental valuation the answer should be criticising.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is feminism an ideology for empowerment or for equality ? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is it X or Y? Discuss" - a disjunction that must be examined before it is accepted
Core issue	Whether equality and empowerment are rivals or stand in a condition-exercise relation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: define both, show the relation, run one tradition contrast, one objection, verdict
Key distinction	Equality as enabling condition against empowerment as effective capacity
Non-negotiables	The disjunction must be shown to be false, not merely declared so; no full ideology may be expounded

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: The disjunction is false, and showing **why** is the answer. Feminism is an ideology for **equal standing, pursued through empowerment**.

The two terms defined. FACT: Equality has three senses: formal, the same rule; substantive, attention to unequal starting positions and effective outcomes; relational, citizens meeting without domination, stigma or servility. FACT: Empowerment is the expansion of resources, capabilities, agency, recognition and institutional influence through which women can make **and act upon** significant choices.

The relation, in three lines. FACT: Equality without agency can be merely **formal**. Agency without structural equality becomes **exceptional individual success** - one woman's achievement, no change in the rule. Empowerment **links rights to actual control and collective transformation**.

Why the traditions divide on this. ANALYSIS: Liberal feminism reads the demand as equality of rights and opportunity; its standard objection is that it underestimates the family and structure. Radical feminism reads it as the transformation of power itself; its weakness is universalising one experience. ANALYSIS: Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill had already located the difficulty: **law and custom jointly** manufacture the subjection, so removing a legal disability leaves the custom untouched.

Objection and reply. FACT: Objection: if equality is achieved, empowerment is redundant. ANALYSIS: Reply: equal standing supplies the entitlement, not the alternatives, the time, the safety or the collective voice; that is why formal equality can coexist with unchanged control.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Equality is the **condition**; empowerment is the **exercise and the reshaping** of that condition. An ideology that sought one without the other would secure either a right nobody can use or an exception that changes no rule.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: an "X or Y" stem tests whether the candidate accepts the framing. Choosing a side answers the question as printed and forfeits the analysis; showing that the two stand in a condition-exercise relation answers the question as intended. The three-line relation is the mark-bearing sentence and should be written in full.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: position one line; definitions four lines; the three-line relation three lines; traditions three lines; objection and reply two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: drop the tradition contrast before dropping the three-line relation, which is the answer itself.

- **Structure:** position -> both terms defined -> the three-line relation -> tradition contrast -> objection and reply -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the three conceptions of equality; empowerment as make **and** act upon significant choices.
- **Evidence:** Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill on law and custom; the liberal and radical diagnoses with their standard objections.
- **Distinction:** enabling condition against effective capacity.
- **Criticism:** the redundancy objection, met by the gap between entitlement and alternatives.

How to improve this answer

Add one line on the **sameness/difference dilemma**, since it explains why an equality-only reading is unstable: a sex-neutral rule may encode a male life-pattern, and an accommodation may essentialise. That converts the verdict from an assertion about the relation into a demonstration of why neither term is self-sufficient. If a further line is available, note that empowerment is measured by the availability of alternatives rather than by outcomes, because it forestalls the reply that better outcomes for women already constitute empowerment. Do **not** expound liberalism or radicalism as complete doctrines; naming the diagnosis and its standard objection is the bounded use this owner permits.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Can gender equality be realised within a socialist regime? Analyse.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Analyse" - decompose the claim; a yes or no without a decomposition scores poorly
Core issue	Whether patriarchy is derivative of class society or autonomous alongside it
Scope boundary	Ten marks: one prediction, what it gets right, the defeater, the residue, a conditional verdict
Key distinction	Marxist feminism's derivative patriarchy against socialist feminism's autonomous one
Non-negotiables	No country, party or period named; historical materialism must not be expounded

Independent model answer

What the stem presupposes. ANALYSIS: The question tests the **Marxist feminist** diagnosis: women's subordination arises with private property and class society and is functional to the property-owning family.

The prediction. FACT: Abolish private property, socialise domestic labour, draw women into social production, and the material basis of subordination is removed.

What the prediction gets right. FACT: The property and inheritance mechanism is real; economic dependence is a genuine lever; and participation in social production does alter bargaining power.

The defeater. FACT: Male dominance is observable across societies with radically different modes of production, and it **persisted where private property in the means of production was abolished**. That is the evidence advanced for patriarchy's **autonomy**.

The residue the diagnosis cannot reach. ANALYSIS: Social reproduction: who performs the unpaid care, who decides about the body, who holds authority **inside** the household, and who is subject to violence and stigma. Socialist feminism widens the analysis to exactly this - two systems, each with its own logic, historically entangled and neither reducible to the other.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: A socialist regime removes **one** structural condition and is therefore necessary on the material axis. It is **not sufficient** unless it also transforms the sexual division of labour, the family, sexuality and care. CAUTION: Socialist feminism pays for the wider diagnosis in explanatory complexity, which should be conceded rather than concealed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a ten-mark "analyse" stem is scored on decomposition. The five-move route - prediction, concession, defeater, residue, conditional verdict - is exactly what "analyse" asks for, and it prevents the two failure modes: an enthusiastic yes and a dismissive no. Naming the derivative/autonomous distinction in the first two lines signals immediately that the candidate knows which dispute is being tested.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: presupposition one line; prediction one line; concession one line; defeater two lines; residue three lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: shorten the residue to care and household authority, but never drop the defeater, which is the evidential core.

- **Structure:** the diagnosis assumed -> its prediction -> what it gets right -> the defeater -> the residue -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** derivative against autonomous patriarchy; the dual-systems formulation.
- **Evidence:** dominance across radically different modes of production; persistence where private property in production was abolished.
- **Distinction:** production against social reproduction as sites of analysis.
- **Criticism:** the reduction defence, and socialist feminism's own complexity weakness.

How to improve this answer

Add one clause noting that the strongest defence of the Marxist position - that the transformation was never completed, since domestic burdens and household authority survived - **concedes the analytical point**, because it makes those sites do independent explanatory work and thereby restates the dual-systems claim. That single observation is worth more than an additional example. If a further line is available, note that radical feminism offers a third position in which patriarchy is primary rather than derivative or interacting, since the stem's word "analyse" rewards showing that the field contains three positions and not two.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Consider critically that gender discrimination is a rather man-made concept but not naturally endowed.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Consider critically" - the objection-and-reply layer is the answer, not an appendix
Core issue	Whether the constructionist claim survives the appeal to biological difference and to constancy
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the inference claim, the five-step argument, two objections with replies, verdict
Key distinction	Origin of a category against its strength; construction against unreality
Non-negotiables	Both crude essences must be refused; the presupposition must be named

Independent model answer

The claim, stated precisely. ANALYSIS: "Man-made" does not mean invented or unreal. It means that the **inference** from bodily difference to social role, authority and property is a social judgment, not an entailment.

The five-step argument. FACT: Societies assign meanings and roles to bodily difference; those roles structure education, work, care, mobility, inheritance and authority; repeated expectation is internalised and begins to appear natural; institutional outcomes reinforce the original norm; therefore observed inequality **cannot** be inferred to be biologically necessary. **ANALYSIS:** The presupposition - social practice shapes preferences, capacities and self-conception - must be stated, since step three depends on it.

Why the circle is self-confirming. ANALYSIS: The arrangement produces the very evidence later offered as its justification. "They do not lead" is an output of the arrangement, so an appeal to observed regularity settles nothing.

First objection: biological difference. FACT: Some role differences reflect reproduction. **Reply:** biological facts do not determine who controls property, whose work is valued or who has authority; those conclusions require an independent justification never supplied.

Second objection: constancy. ANALYSIS: If the pattern recurs across radically different societies, is that not evidence of nature? **Reply:** the content of the roles varies while the **function** - assigning immanence - recurs, so the constancy is institutional rather than biological.

Two errors to refuse. WRONG: Sex purely natural and gender purely artificial replaces one essence with two. WRONG: "Constructed" read as unreal ignores that money, citizenship and caste are constructed and coercive alike.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The proposition is defensible once "man-made" is read as **socially produced and institutionally sustained**, not as arbitrary or easily revised.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: on a "consider critically" stem the objections are the answer. A script that expounds constructionism and adds a paragraph of criticism has inverted the weighting. Running two objections with replies, and then refusing both crude readings, uses the whole of the available structure.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: claim two lines; five-step argument four lines; the loop two lines; two objections with replies four lines; two errors two lines; verdict one line. Compression plan: keep both objections and drop the second error, since the biological and constancy objections are what the directive is asking for.

- **Structure:** precise claim -> five-step argument with its presupposition -> the self-confirming loop -> two objections with replies -> two errors refused -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the sex/gender distinction as a claim about an inference; construction without unreality.
- **Evidence:** the norm-to-outcome chain; the money, citizenship and caste parallel; Beauvoir on the Other.
- **Distinction:** origin of a category against its strength.
- **Criticism:** the biological-difference objection and the constancy objection, each with a reply.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence stating that a socially constructed category is not thereby easy to change, because the whole force of the reply to the constancy objection depends on institutions being durable - and a script that has called gender "man-made" without that qualification invites the response that it could therefore be unmade by decision. If two further lines are available, note that Beauvoir's constitution of woman as the Other supplies the classical statement of the same denial, since a named anchor converts a reconstruction into a positioned argument. Do **not** introduce performativity here unless space clearly permits: it is a depth marker on the category stems and can crowd out the objection layer this directive rewards.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2020 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: Do you agree that empowering women can eliminate gender discrimination? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Do you agree... Discuss" with the strong verb "eliminate" - a modal claim requiring a mechanism and a limit
Core issue	Whether a change in the position of the disadvantaged group can dissolve a structural injustice
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: definition, mechanism, reach, limit, the structural reason, two objections, verdict
Key distinction	Better provision against empowerment; individual achievement against institutional reproduction
Non-negotiables	The limit must be derived from the diagnosis, not asserted; the burden must not be placed on women

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: Empowerment is **necessary and transformative** and cannot be **sufficient**, and the reason is a consequence of how the discrimination was diagnosed.

Definition first. FACT: Empowerment is the expansion of resources, capabilities, agency, recognition and institutional influence through which women can make **and act upon** significant choices. Following Kabeer, resources are preconditions, agency is the process, achievements are outcomes - and the decisive component is **agency**, tested by the availability of alternatives and the cost of exercising them.

What empowerment genuinely reaches. ANALYSIS: It weakens dependence, challenges stereotypes, increases accountability, improves the fall-back position and therefore bargaining power inside the household, and expands the strategic life choices actually open to a woman - marriage, childbearing, whether and where to work, freedom of movement, and control over her own body. ANALYSIS: These are not modest gains, and an answer that hurries past them to the limitation has not earned the limitation.

Why elimination does not follow. FACT: Gender injustice is **structural**: normal rules, institutions and repeated choices combine to constrain a group without any actor designing the result. Responsibility for it is therefore forward-looking and shared, graded by power, privilege, interest and collective capacity to change the process. An injustice of that shape is sustained by many agents' ordinary choices, so it cannot be dissolved by changing the position of the disadvantaged group alone.

What it cannot reach alone. ANALYSIS: Unequal care burdens fixed by others' choices and by the organisation of work; violence, whose control lies with the perpetrator and the enforcement system; cultural valuation held by other people and not renegotiable one household at a time; institutional design she did not write; and intra-household allocation no individual can alter unilaterally.

Two objections. FACT: *Measurement*: enrolment, accounts and asset transfers show empowerment. **Reply**: those record preconditions; an improvement in outcomes without expanded agency is better provision. FACT: *Defeatism*: the verdict demoralises. **Reply**: it reallocates effort and prevents the characteristic failure in which empowerment rhetoric shifts the burden onto women.

The completeness test. ANALYSIS: Any remedy must operate in three dimensions at once - redistribution of resources, time and care; recognition of equal status; representation in authoritative decision. Representation without agency is tokenism; recognition without redistribution celebrates identity while preserving dependence; resources without voice become paternalistic provision.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Empowerment must be **joined to institutional reform and men's participation** in changing gendered power. CAUTION: The mechanism for delivering that second half remains far less developed than the first.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem invites affirmation, and affirmation is the failure mode. The scored structure is build-then-limit: state fully what empowerment reaches before naming what it cannot, and then **derive** the insufficiency from the structural diagnosis rather than asserting it. A script that reaches "necessary but not sufficient" without the derivation has produced a formula; one that derives it has produced an argument.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: position one line; definition four lines; reach three lines; the structural reason three lines; the five limits four lines; two objections four lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: reduce the five limits to care, violence and others' valuations, and keep the derivation, which is the answer's spine.

- **Structure:** position -> definition -> what it reaches -> the structural reason -> what it cannot reach -> two objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** resources, agency, achievements; structural injustice and shared forward-looking responsibility.
- **Evidence:** Kabeer's strategic life choices and the alternatives test; the social-connection model; the fall-back position.
- **Distinction:** better provision against empowerment.
- **Criticism:** the measurement objection and the defeatism objection, each answered.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence noting that this owner names **empowerment rhetoric that shifts the burden to women** as a criticism in its own right, since quoting the criticism against oneself pre-empts the strongest reading of the defeatism objection. If two further lines are available, apply the three dimensions as a completeness test - representation without agency is tokenism, recognition without redistribution celebrates identity while preserving dependence, and resources without voice become paternalistic provision - because that converts the verdict from a limitation into a specification of the accompanying reforms.

Solved PYQ 6 · 2021 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How far can land and property rights be effective in empowerment of women? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How far... Explain" - a degree judgment is compulsory, with the conditions of holding and of failing
Core issue	Whether an entitlement converts into effective command over an asset
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the five levels, the fall-back argument, one conversion failure, a graded verdict
Key distinction	Ownership against effective control and realised benefit
Non-negotiables	Agarwal must be credited; the bargaining premise must be stated; no ownership figure may appear

Independent model answer

The degree claim. ANALYSIS: Land and property rights are effective **exactly as far as they convert**, and conversion is a chain of five separate achievements.

The five levels. FACT: Following **Bina Agarwal, *A Field of One's Own* (1994)**: **title** - is her name in law or record? **access** - can she use it? **control** - can she decide about cropping, leasing, sale? **return** - does the income reach her? **exit** - does it protect her against abandonment or violence? Each fails separately: records and custom lag the law; distance, safety and seclusion block access; decision-power follows household authority; proceeds are pooled by others.

Where the political value lies. ANALYSIS: At the fifth level. A woman's position inside the household depends on her **fall-back position** - what she could command if the relationship ended - and independent rights strengthen it as mediated access cannot. ANALYSIS: The premise is that intra-household allocation is a site of **bargaining**, not unified altruistic decision.

The second argument. FACT: Equal inheritance also **recognises daughters as full members** rather than temporary dependants - a status claim that holds even where income does not follow.

Graded verdict. ANALYSIS: Effective to the degree that title is joined to access, control, return and a credible exit; ineffective where it remains a record entry. FACT: Title is the **necessary anchor** without which the higher levels have nothing to attach to.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how far" requires a degree, not a balance. The five levels supply the degree directly, because they specify what would have to be true for the answer to be "far" and what makes it "not far". Naming Agarwal and stating the bargaining premise are the two moves that mark the answer as philosophical rather than administrative.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: degree claim one line; five levels five lines; fall-back position three lines; recognition argument two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: state the five levels as a single sentence chain if pressed, but keep the fall-back argument, which is the analytical core.

- **Structure:** degree claim -> the five levels with failure modes -> the fall-back position -> the recognition argument -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** ownership, effective control and realised benefit; land as bargaining power.
- **Evidence:** Agarwal, *A Field of One's Own* (1994); the intra-household bargaining premise.
- **Distinction:** entitlement against command.
- **Criticism:** the misdirected-effort objection, met by title as necessary anchor.

How to improve this answer

Add one clause conceding that the intervening conditions - records, credit, market access, safety, decision-power - are **slower, more diffuse and harder to legislate than title itself**, because that concession is what prevents the verdict from sounding like a criticism of legal reform. If a further line is available, note that the third standard objection - that liberation should not depend on private ownership - is met by the anti-dependence principle, since even under social ownership women require enforceable control, housing security, livelihood access and equal voice.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: What are the main causes of female foeticide in India? Is it the result of demonic application of technology only? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two questions joined: a causal enumeration and a refutation of a proposed sole cause
Core issue	Whether the diagnostic instrument explains a discriminatory pattern
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: an ordered architecture, the technology reply, one classified instrument, verdict
Key distinction	Means against reason; instrument against origin
Non-negotiables	The word "only" must be answered directly; no ratio or region; the autonomy caveat must survive

Independent model answer

The two demands. ANALYSIS: The stem asks for causes **and** offers a decoy. The correct answer is an ordered architecture in which technology occupies the last storey.

The architecture. FACT: **Patrilineal inheritance and lineage** - the daughter leaves, the son continues line and property, so a daughter is constituted as a transfer and a son as an addition. FACT: **Expectations of sons as economic or ritual support** - old-age security and ritual duty assigned by sex. FACT: **Dowry and marriage costs** - a daughter constituted as a future liability. FACT: **Unequal property and earning power** - if she cannot own, earn or control, the expectation that she cannot support becomes self-fulfilling. FACT: **Family pressure and constrained reproductive agency** - the woman who decides is frequently not the woman choosing.

The answer to "only". ANALYSIS: Technology functions as an **instrument of pre-existing bias, not its sole cause**. Two considerations settle it. The definition covers a foetus identified **or presumed** to be female, so the wrong does not require a test. And the same equipment has entirely legitimate diagnostic uses, so an instrument cannot explain a pattern its ordinary applications do not produce. ANALYSIS: Technology supplies the **means**; patriarchy supplies the **reason**.

The Indian instrument, classified. FACT: The PCPNDT Act, **1994**, expanded by amendment to pre-conception selection, is an enacted regulatory and penal statute. ANALYSIS: It reaches supply and public signalling; it cannot reach the preference.

Objection. FACT: If the preference is structural, is prohibition futile? **Reply:** it withdraws the instrument from routine availability and places the public meaning on record, and neither effect requires the preference to have weakened.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The causes are structural and ordered; the instrument is real but derivative. WRONG: "Demonic application of technology" names the means and mistakes it for the cause.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem's word "only" is the whole examination. A script that lists causes and adds "technology is also a factor" has not answered it. The scored move is to **order** the causes so that the ordering itself shows why the instrument cannot be the explanation, and then to supply two independent reasons - the "or presumed" clause and the legitimate diagnostic uses.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: the two demands one line; architecture six lines; the technology reply four lines; instrument two lines; objection two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: merge the second and third causes if pressed, but never compress the technology reply, which is the stem's actual target.

- **Structure:** two demands identified -> ordered architecture -> the reply to "only" -> classified instrument -> futility objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** causes as a normative structure; technology as instrument of a pre-existing bias.
- **Evidence:** the six-level architecture; the definitional phrase "identified or presumed"; PCPNDT Act, 1994.
- **Distinction:** means against reason.
- **Criticism:** the futility objection, met by supply withdrawal and public record.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence connecting the architecture to the fourth cause explicitly: unequal earning power makes the expectation that a daughter cannot support **self-fulfilling**, which is the same self-confirming loop that runs through the whole clause and shows the causes to be a system rather than a list. If two further lines are available, note that the regulatory target should be discriminatory diagnostic and commercial practice, providers and coercive family structures rather than the pregnant woman, since the 2021 stem's framing invites an answer that would otherwise slide into policing her.

Solved PYQ 8 · 2022 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss gender as a cultural category as opposed to sex as a biological category.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss... as opposed to" - a contrast to be worked, then qualified; not a partition to be drawn
Core issue	How a category described as cultural acquires enforceable force
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the contrast, the six channels, the parallels, one depth marker, verdict
Key distinction	Origin of a category against its strength
Non-negotiables	Both crude readings refused; the interaction qualification stated; no partition

Independent model answer

How to read "opposed". ANALYSIS: As **contrasted**, not partitioned. The two are categories of different things - bodily and reproductive characteristics on one side, socially produced roles, expectations and identities on the other - but they **interact**, since pregnancy, illness and ageing are at once bodily and socially organised.

The contrast, stated. FACT: Sex names bodily and reproductive characteristics, with the qualification that biological variation is more complex than a rigid social binary. FACT: Gender names socially produced roles and identities. FACT: Gender hierarchy names the patterned ranking of masculinised over feminised roles - and **not every difference is discriminatory**; unjust subordination is the issue.

How a cultural category acquires force - six channels. FACT: **Family** allocates food, education, inheritance and mobility. **Language** supplies the unmarked default. **Labour** decides which work is paid and which is "natural". **Law** governs succession, guardianship and marriage. **Media** fix the repertoire of imaginable lives. **Sanction** - ridicule, exclusion, coercion - attaches a **cost** to departure. ANALYSIS: The sixth channel is what converts a norm from a description into a constraint.

Construction is not unreality. FACT: Money, citizenship and caste are socially constructed and all three are enforceable. Construction is a claim about **origin**, not about strength.

The depth marker. ANALYSIS: Butler presses further: the categories through which bodies are read as sexed are themselves produced within a gendered discourse, so gender is sustained by **compelled reiteration** rather than expressed from an inner essence. CAUTION: The category-stability objection and the strategic-essentialism reply must travel with it, and the exchange is live.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Gender is **cultural in origin and material in effect**: made by institutions, and distributing opportunity, rights and resources as reliably as any natural law would have done.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem's "as opposed to" invites a wall, and the wall is the error. The scored structure contrasts the categories, states the interaction, and then spends most of the answer on the **mechanism** by which a cultural category acquires force - because that is what an examiner is testing when a candidate calls something cultural.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: reading of "opposed" two lines; the contrast three lines; six channels four lines; parallels two lines; Butler two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: reduce the six channels to labour, law and sanction, keeping sanction under all circumstances.

- **Structure:** how to read "opposed" -> the contrast with qualifications -> six embodiment channels -> construction against unreality -> Butler as depth marker -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** gender as cultural category; performativity as a contesting rather than restating move.
- **Evidence:** the six channels; the money, citizenship and caste parallel; Butler, *Gender Trouble* (1990).
- **Distinction:** origin against strength; contrast against partition.
- **Criticism:** the unreality objection and the category-stability objection.

How to improve this answer

Add one line stating that the cultural reading **explains variation and persistence at once** - different societies assign different content to the same bodily difference, and internalisation with sanction and institutional reinforcement makes the arrangement stable - since a single sentence there answers the two commonest sceptical questions about constructionism. If two further lines are available, note the two errors explicitly as errors: the two-essence reading and the unreality reading, because naming a misreading and refusing it is a stronger move than avoiding it silently.

Solved PYQ 9 · 2023 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: Do you agree that the rights concerning land and property have empowered women? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Do you agree... have empowered" - a perfective conversion claim, not a question about existence
Core issue	Whether an established entitlement has become effective command
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the classified record, the four conversion failures, the recognition concession, verdict
Key distinction	Entitlement settled against possession and control not established
Non-negotiables	Status and date for each instrument; the conversion caveat; no ownership figure

Independent model answer

Reading the stem. ANALYSIS: The verb is "have empowered", so this is a **conversion** question. Establishing that such rights exist answers a question that was not asked.

The record, classified. FACT: The Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, **2005**, is an **enacted amendment** giving daughters in a Mitakshara joint family coparcenary status by birth on the statutory terms. FACT: **Vineeta Sharma v. Rakesh Sharma (2020)** is a **Supreme Court judgment** clarifying that right, including that the father need not have been alive at commencement. ANALYSIS: Together they settle **entitlement and interpretation**.

Why that is not empowerment. FACT: Four conversion failures, none of them a defect in the law: **waiver pressure**, framed as family loyalty; **informal partition**, keeping the division outside the record; **record practices**, maintained by the social order the law was meant to change; and **fear of family rupture**, which attaches a relational price to claiming.

Where the failures sit. ANALYSIS: All four operate at the access, control, return and exit levels - **inside the household**. That is why the property question becomes the public/private question.

The concession. FACT: The **recognition** gain is real and independent: equal inheritance marks daughters as full members rather than temporary dependants, and that status change does not wait on possession.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Partially, and asymmetrically: recognition has advanced, control has not followed, and the instruments settle entitlement without establishing possession, return or exit.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: ten-mark parts reward exact reading. "Have empowered" is perfective and its object is empowerment, so the answer must be a conversion audit. The asymmetric verdict - recognition yes, control not yet - is more precise than either agreement or disagreement and is what a "do you agree" stem is actually testing.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: reading one line; classified record three lines; four failures four lines; where they sit two lines; concession two lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: name two conversion failures rather than four, but keep the recognition concession, which produces the asymmetry.

- **Structure:** read the verb -> classify the record -> four conversion failures -> locate them -> recognition concession -> asymmetric verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the five-level ladder applied to a real reform; entitlement against command.
- **Evidence:** Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005; *Vineeta Sharma* (2020); the four conversion failures.
- **Distinction:** what an instrument settles against what it establishes.

- **Criticism:** the objection that legal reform is therefore misdirected, met by title as necessary anchor.

How to improve this answer

Add one clause noting that the four failures are **not** defects in the statute, because that observation is what converts a list of obstacles into an argument about where the law cannot reach - and it is also what routes the answer into the public/private analysis rather than into administrative complaint. If a further line is available, credit Agarwal for the ownership-control-benefit separation, since the attribution is required by this owner and it signals that the conversion vocabulary is being used deliberately rather than improvised.

Solved PYQ 10 · 2023 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does gender discrimination lead to female foeticide and social imbalance? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does X lead to Y and Z" - a causal chain with two terminal points, both to be reached
Core issue	Tracing the mechanism from norm to selection and onward to second-order harms
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the chain, both terminals, the ordering of dignity and consequence, verdict
Key distinction	Discriminatory valuation as the ground against demographic consequence as an effect
Non-negotiables	Dignity must precede consequence; no ratio; the consequentialist trap must be refused explicitly

Independent model answer

The chain, drawn. ANALYSIS: **Norm** - a daughter is constituted as a cost through inheritance, ritual expectation and marriage cost. **Institution** - kinship, marriage, succession and the paid/unpaid boundary embed it. **Allocation** - the institution distributes food, health care, schooling, time, mobility, property, safety and, at the limit, **continued life**. **Outcome** - inequality in each. **Internalisation** - the outcome appears ordinary. **Justification** - the outcome is then cited as proof the norm was right.

Terminal one: foeticide. FACT: Sex-selective termination is the allocation link operating on the most basic good at the earliest moment. ANALYSIS: Its wrong is **discriminatory valuation**: female status made a reason for exclusion from birth, with repeated decisions composing a public meaning that daughters are less worthy - a meaning that harms daughters who are born.

Terminal two: social imbalance. ANALYSIS: A distorted sex composition can intensify trafficking, coerced marriage and violence. ANALYSIS: The mark-bearing observation is the direction of that harm: **it falls again on women**. The consequence redistributes harm onto the group whose devaluation began the sequence.

The ordering the stem requires. WRONG: Consequences are not the reason the practice is wrong. It is wrong first because **equal dignity is denied**. Arguing that society "needs women" instrumentalises women a second time, reproducing the valuation the argument set out to reject.

The continuum. FACT: Sen's missing-women argument shows the same devaluation across birth, nutrition, health and survival, so selection is the extreme point of a continuum rather than an isolated act.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Discrimination reaches foeticide because life is an allocated good, and reaches imbalance because the harm it produces returns to the same group - so imbalance **aggravates** the wrong rather than constituting it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a "how does X lead to Y and Z" stem is scored on the chain and on reaching **both** terminals. The characteristic failure is arriving at imbalance and treating it as the reason for condemnation. Stating the ordering explicitly - dignity as the ground, imbalance as an aggravating effect - is what distinguishes the answer.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: chain five lines; first terminal three lines; second terminal three lines; ordering three lines; continuum one line; verdict two lines. Compression plan: shorten the chain to norm, institution, allocation, but keep the ordering paragraph, which the directive is testing.

- **Structure:** the five-link chain -> foeticide as terminal one -> imbalance as terminal two -> the ordering of dignity and consequence -> the continuum -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the discrimination mechanism with continued life as an allocated good; the consequentialist trap.
- **Evidence:** the norm-to-justification chain; Sen's missing-women continuum.
- **Distinction:** ground against effect.
- **Criticism:** the outcome objection, refused because a reason that would evaporate with the demography was never the reason.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence noting that the wrong comprises **both** discriminatory valuation and constrained agency, since the woman making the decision may herself act under coercive family and economic conditions - which prevents the chain from being read as an accusation against her and shows that two distinct remedies are required. If two further lines are available, close by naming the four remedial targets - norms, property, security and accountability - because a causal answer that ends without a remedy has left the "discuss" instruction half-executed.

Solved PYQ 11 · 2024 · Q4(a) · 10+10=20 marks

Question: Discuss gender equality as a necessary condition to achieve empowerment of women. Also examine the role of women empowerment in curbing the menace of female foeticide.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two separately marked halves: a modal claim, then a causal-evaluative one
Core issue	Whether equality is necessary for empowerment, and whether empowerment reaches the preference behind selection
Scope boundary	Twenty marks split 10 and 10; both halves must be visibly answered and roughly balanced
Key distinction	Necessary against sufficient; underlying conditions against the diagnostic act
Non-negotiables	Both halves attempted; the pathway's speed limit stated; no ratio or scheme used as proof

Independent model answer

Half one - equality as a necessary condition. ANALYSIS: It is necessary and not sufficient, and both halves of that need arguing.

Why necessary. FACT: Equal legal standing, education, property and bodily security are **enabling conditions**; empowerment is the effective capacity to use and reshape them. Without equal standing there is no entitlement to exercise, so the relation is not merely helpful but constitutive.

Why not sufficient. FACT: Equality without agency can be merely **formal**; agency without structural equality becomes **exceptional individual success**. Empowerment is what links rights to actual control and collective transformation - and standing supplies neither the alternatives, nor the time, nor the safety, nor the collective voice. ANALYSIS: The sameness/difference dilemma shows why: a sex-neutral rule may encode a male life-pattern as its hidden norm, while an accommodation of difference may essentialise the burden it relieves, so equal standing alone does not settle what treatment equality requires.

The test. ANALYSIS: Following Kabeer, resources are preconditions, agency the process, achievements outcomes; the decisive component is **agency**, tested by the availability of alternatives and the cost of exercising them. An improvement in outcomes without expanded agency is better provision, not empowerment.

Half two - empowerment against female foeticide. ANALYSIS: A pathway with five links, followed by its limit.

The pathway. FACT: **Property, education and income** alter the perceived status of daughters, so a daughter ceases to be constituted as a pure liability. FACT: **Bodily and household agency** reduces coercive reproductive decisions, so the woman deciding becomes the woman choosing. FACT: **Public voice** contests the discriminatory norm and therefore the public meaning that many private decisions compose. FACT: **Social security** reduces the instrumental preference for sons by detaching old-age support from sex. ANALYSIS: Therefore empowerment attacks

the **underlying conditions**, not merely the diagnostic act.

The limit. ANALYSIS: Every link is slower than a prohibition, and none is within any individual woman's control. The PCPNDT Act, **1994**, an enacted regulatory and penal statute, reaches supply and signalling; it cannot reach the preference. ANALYSIS: The wrong is also twofold - discriminatory valuation **and** constrained agency - so the second link does independent work rather than repeating the first.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Equality is the necessary condition of empowerment; empowerment is a necessary and insufficient instrument against selection, and both must be joined to institutional reform.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: split-marked parts are lost by imbalance. Each half needs its own visible structure and roughly equal space. The first half is scored on running necessity and sufficiency **separately**; the second on building the pathway and then locating its limit rather than asserting that empowerment solves the problem.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: half one nine lines; half two eleven lines; verdict two lines. Compression plan: within half two reduce the pathway to status, agency and social security, but keep the speed limit, which is what the word "examine" rewards.

- **Structure:** necessity -> insufficiency -> the agency test -> the five-link pathway -> its limit -> joint verdict.
- **Doctrine:** equality as enabling condition; empowerment as expanded strategic choice; the causal pathway to son preference.
- **Evidence:** the three-line equality/empowerment relation; Kabeer's alternatives test; PCPNDT Act, 1994, classified.
- **Distinction:** necessary against sufficient; underlying conditions against the diagnostic act.
- **Criticism:** the objection that empowerment shifts the burden to women, met by the joint verdict.

How to improve this answer

Add one line to the first half observing that the sameness/difference dilemma shows why equality alone is unstable - a sex-neutral rule may encode a male life-pattern while an accommodation may essentialise - since that converts "not sufficient" from an assertion into a demonstration. If two further lines are available, add to the second half that the wrong of selection is twofold, valuation **and** constrained agency, because it explains precisely why the second link of the pathway is doing independent work rather than repeating the first.

Solved PYQ 12 · 2025 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: How does gender as a social construct affect individuals' opportunities, rights, and access to resources? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does... Critically discuss" - a mechanism traced to three named objects, plus a critical layer
Core issue	How a constructed category distributes three specific goods
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the mechanism compressed, the three terminals, one objection with a reply
Key distinction	Construction as origin against distribution as effect
Non-negotiables	The stem's three objects must each be answered, in the stem's own order; no data

Independent model answer

The claim. ANALYSIS: Gender is **cultural in origin and material in effect**: constructed through institutions, and distributing goods as reliably as a natural law would have done.

The mechanism, compressed. FACT: A socially organised meaning attached to sex is embedded in durable institutions - family, marriage, inheritance, the paid/unpaid boundary, schooling, personal law; those institutions allocate; the allocation produces inequality; the inequality is internalised; and the outcome is then cited as evidence that the norm was right. ANALYSIS: The circle is **self-confirming**.

Opportunities. FACT: Schooling, mobility, safety and the paid/unpaid boundary decide which futures are reachable; unpaid care depletes **time**, which is itself a resource.

Rights. FACT: Recognition in law is only the first level. Standing to claim, and the capacity to enforce without family rupture, decide whether a right is exercisable.

Access to resources. ANALYSIS: Following Agarwal, title, access, control, return and exit are five separate achievements; a nominal title without possession, credit or decision-power may not empower.

The critical layer. FACT: Objection: a constructed category should be revisable by decision. **Reply:** money, citizenship and caste are also constructed and all are enforceable - construction names the origin, not the strength. ANALYSIS: Second, "individuals" are not uniform: caste, class, community, disability and sexuality produce a **distinct mechanism** at their intersection.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: A construct distributes; and because it distributes through institutions, the remedy must be institutional.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem names three objects and expects all three. Answering "opportunities, rights and access to resources" in the stem's own order is worth marks by itself, and the critical layer is supplied by the unreality objection plus the intersectional qualification rather than by generalised criticism.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: claim one line; mechanism three lines; three terminals five lines; critical layer three lines; verdict one line. Compression plan: compress the mechanism to a single sentence, never the three terminals.

- **Structure:** claim -> compressed mechanism -> opportunities -> rights -> resources -> critical layer -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the discrimination mechanism with its self-confirming loop; the five-level ladder.
- **Evidence:** the six embodiment channels in compressed form; Agarwal's five levels; the constructed-and-coercive parallel.
- **Distinction:** origin against strength; recognition of a right against capacity to exercise it.
- **Criticism:** the revisability objection and the intersectional under-description objection.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence on **structural responsibility**, noting that because the outcome is produced by many ordinary choices inside normal institutions, duties are forward-looking and shared rather than a matter of blame - the 2025 stem's word "individuals" invites exactly this, and it converts a distributive answer into a normative one. If a further line is available, state that time is the resource most often omitted from such lists, since unpaid care depletes it and its depletion is what constrains access to the other two objects the stem names.

Six original questions in the paper's own idiom - two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 - each solved to the same standard as the previous-year parts above. None reproduces an owned stem; each targets a route the corpus has tested indirectly or is likely to test again. **Anti-essentialism, structural responsibility, the public/private boundary, care ethics, intersectional category-scepticism and the equality/difference dilemma are deliberately represented here**, since each is printed inside this owner's material and none carries a directly owned part in the 2018-2025 cycle.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Does the claim that gender is performative strengthen or weaken feminist political argument? Explain.

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: It strengthens the diagnosis and complicates the politics, and both halves must be stated.

The claim. ANALYSIS: On Butler's account (*Gender Trouble*, 1990) gender is produced by compelled, reiterated stylised acts that manufacture the appearance of a natural inner identity - there is **no doer behind the deed**. It goes beyond the standard sex/gender distinction by denying that the bodily substrate is met pre-interpretively.

How it strengthens. FACT: It removes the last refuge of essentialism. If even the categories through which bodies are read are socially produced, no appeal to a natural substrate can justify an allocation of role or authority. And because the arrangement depends on repetition, it is vulnerable to failed and parodic repetition - change becomes intelligible.

How it complicates. ANALYSIS: The **category problem**: mobilisation, anti-discrimination law and measurement all presuppose a determinate subject, and a thoroughgoing anti-essentialism appears to dissolve the constituency feminism defends.

The reply and its residue. ANALYSIS: **Strategic essentialism** permits provisionally stabilised categories while conceding their historical construction, much as anti-discrimination law already operates. CAUTION: But a category adopted for leverage tends to harden into a description and to marginalise those it fits badly.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Performativity is a **depth marker**, not a default: decisive on constitution stems, and unnecessary on property, empowerment and foeticide stems, where the space belongs to mechanism and evidence.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a "strengthens or weakens" stem is scored on refusing the disjunction with a reason. The reason here is that the thesis operates at the level of diagnosis while the difficulty operates at the level of political subjecthood, so the two are not in competition.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: position one line; the claim three lines; strengthens three lines; complicates two lines; reply and residue three lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** position -> the claim -> how it strengthens -> how it complicates -> reply with residue -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** performativity as compelled reiteration; strategic essentialism.
- **Evidence:** Butler, *Gender Trouble* (1990); the operation of legal sex-discrimination categories.
- **Distinction:** diagnosis against political subjecthood.
- **Criticism:** the category-stability objection, presented as live rather than settled.

How to improve this answer

Add the three cautions explicitly - that the thesis contests rather than restates the standard distinction, that it does not deny that bodies exist, and that performativity is not a freely chosen costume - because each is separately examinable and each is a misreading an examiner will be watching for. If a further line is available, note that the possibility of subversive repetition is what supplies an account of change, since an anti-essentialism with no theory of transformation would indeed be politically weakening.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: If no one designs gender inequality, can anyone be held responsible for it? Discuss.

Independent model answer

The problem. ANALYSIS: Gender oppression is **structural**: normal rules, institutions and repeated choices combine to constrain a group without one actor designing the result.

Two bad answers, refused. WRONG: **Collective guilt** - everyone in the advantaged group is to blame - fails because blame attaches to acts and cannot distinguish an actor with power over the process from one with almost none. WRONG: **The universal excuse** - it is the system, so no one is responsible - fails because the system is nothing but a very large number of ordinary choices.

The distinction that resolves it. ANALYSIS: **Backward-looking blame** attaches to my acts and asks what I did. **Forward-looking responsibility** attaches to my **participation in a process** and asks what I can help change. An agent may bear no blame and still carry real duties.

How duties are allocated. ANALYSIS: On Young's social-connection model, responsibility is shared and **graded by power, privilege, interest and collective capacity** - so a legislator, an employer, a household head and a dependant do not owe the same thing.

The objection. FACT: Diffuse responsibility lets everyone blame the system. **Reply:** shared duties must be **specified by role and power**; an unspecified duty is no duty.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Responsibility survives the absence of an author by changing form - which is why this injustice cannot be dissolved from one side alone.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem sets a trap in its own wording - "if no one designs it" invites either indictment or exculpation. Naming both bad answers and refusing them before introducing the distinction is what converts the question into an argument.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: problem two lines; two bad answers three lines; the distinction three lines; gradients two lines; objection two lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** the problem -> two bad answers refused -> blame against responsibility -> the four gradients -> objection and reply -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** structural injustice; the social-connection model.
- **Evidence:** Young, *Responsibility for Justice*; the four gradients of power, privilege, interest and capacity.
- **Distinction:** acts against participation.
- **Criticism:** the dilution objection, met by specification of duties by role and power.

How to improve this answer

Add one sentence applying the model to the household - a protected sphere of intimacy but not an immunity zone for domination - because it shows the distinction doing work in the sphere where this clause's conversion failures actually occur. If a further line is available, concede that the four gradients are qualitative and yield no determinate quantum of duty, since acknowledging the indeterminacy is stronger than leaving an examiner to find it.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that the family is an object of justice rather than a boundary to it.

Independent model answer

The boundary in question. ANALYSIS: Political philosophy has treated contract, citizenship, rights and the market as the domain of justice, and marriage, household, care and upbringing as pre-political. The claim under examination denies that the line is neutral.

Two arguments, with different targets. ANALYSIS: **Pateman** (*The Sexual Contract*, 1988) attacks the **foundation**: the public contract among free and equal citizens presupposes a prior sexual contract securing men's access to women's bodies and labour, and contract narratives are silent on the marriage contract and on the domestic subordination that makes male civic equality practicable. **WRONG:** Her thesis is an **interpretive reconstruction of those silences**, not a historical claim that any such contract was made. **ANALYSIS:** **Okin** (*Justice, Gender, and the Family*, 1989) works **within** the framework: the unequal domestic burden restricts access to the very primary goods public justice distributes - time, income, position, self-respect - and the family is where a sense of justice is first formed or fails to form.

Why the difference matters. ANALYSIS: One requires the theory to be rebuilt; the other requires it to be extended. Naming that difference is doing philosophy rather than listing feminists.

Why the claim is needed here. ANALYSIS: The conversion ladder fails at access, control, return and exit - all decided inside the household. Without this analysis the failure of a legal entitlement to arrive looks administrative; with it, the failure is located in an institution justice had been told not to examine.

The objection. FACT: Intimacy depends on trust rather than adjudication, and subjecting the family to justice would destroy the goods it exists to produce. **Reply:** justice can operate through **background conditions** - marriage and divorce rules, succession, independent income, recognition of unpaid work, accessible exit - without adjudicating individual interactions.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The household is a **protected sphere of intimacy but not an immunity zone for domination**. CAUTION: Where background conditions end and internal adjudication begins is contested, and family violence stresses the line hardest.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "examine" rewards the objection layer. The scored moves are distinguishing foundational challenge from internal reform, and answering the privacy objection with the background-conditions distinction rather than dismissing it.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: boundary two lines; two arguments six lines; the difference two lines; relevance three lines; objection and reply three lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** the boundary -> Pateman and Okin with their targets -> why the difference matters -> relevance to conversion -> privacy objection and reply -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the public/private division; the family as an object of justice.
- **Evidence:** Pateman (1988); Okin (1989); the four primary goods.
- **Distinction:** foundational challenge against internal extension; background conditions against adjudication.
- **Criticism:** the privacy objection, answered without denying the interest it protects.

How to improve this answer

Add one line noting Okin's own limit - that extending justice into every intimate relationship risks over-reach, which is why most syntheses retain some family autonomy - because conceding a limit on the position one is defending is what the directive "examine" is measuring. If two further lines are available, state that Pateman's argument, if accepted, bears directly on the framework owned by **Individual and State**, since identifying a cross-owner consequence demonstrates control of the boundary rather than a breach of it.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Does an ethic of care correct or endanger the feminist critique of gender roles? Critically examine.

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: It corrects a genuine omission and carries a genuine danger, and the defensible version is the one that survives the danger.

What it corrects. ANALYSIS: **Gilligan** (*In a Different Voice*, 1982) argued that dominant accounts of moral development, framed around abstract rules, rights and impartial justice, systematically registered women's moral reasoning as **deficient**, and identified an equally developed alternative organised around responsibility, relationship and context. Three corrections follow. **FACT:** It exposes the **unpaid care economy** as political rather than private, since the burden constraining access to education, employment, mobility and public office is care work. **FACT:** It supplies a vocabulary for **dependency** - infancy, illness, disability, old age - which contract-based theories handle badly because dependants cannot bargain. ANALYSIS: And it identifies **time** as a resource that unequally distributed care depletes, making caring obligations a structural constraint on agency rather than a personal choice.

The danger. **FACT:** Attributing a distinctive moral voice to women risks re-inscribing the stereotype of the naturally nurturing woman that feminism set out to contest, and can be used to justify confining women to caring roles.

The defensible version. ANALYSIS: Treat the care orientation as arising from **socially assigned position and experience**, not from nature, and as available to anyone so positioned. On that reading care ethics is a critique of how moral theory was constructed, not a claim about female psychology. CAUTION: The empirical claim that the orientations divide along gender lines is contested, and this reply substantially reduces the original thesis.

The second objection. **FACT:** Care without justice leaves domination inside relationships unexamined, since exploitative relationships can be sustained by care. **Reply:** the two are **complementary** - justice supplies the limits that prevent care from becoming self-erasure, and care supplies the attentiveness that prevents justice from becoming formalism.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: It corrects, provided it is stated in the socially-positioned form and paired with justice; stated as a claim about women's nature it endangers the critique it was meant to extend.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "correct or endanger" is another false disjunction, and the scored move is to make the answer turn on **which version** of the thesis is being assessed. The socially-positioned reading is the hinge, and the concession that it reduces the original claim is what makes the examination critical.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: position one line; what it corrects six lines; the danger two lines; the defensible version three lines; second objection three lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** position -> three corrections -> the essentialism danger -> the socially-positioned reading -> the care-without-justice objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the ethic of care; justice and care as complementary.
- **Evidence:** Gilligan (1982); the justice/care contrast in question, self-conception, reasoning mode and failure mode.
- **Distinction:** a claim about moral theory's construction against a claim about female psychology.
- **Criticism:** essentialism, and the neglect of domination inside relationships.

How to improve this answer

Add one clause pairing the socially-positioned reading with Butler's anti-essentialism, because the two positions are mutually reinforcing on exactly this point and naming the pairing shows the field being handled rather than reported. If two further lines are available, note the four-cell justice/care contrast - moral question, self-conception, reasoning mode, failure mode - since the failure-mode row, indifference against self-effacement, is what makes the complementarity verdict non-arbitrary.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Women is too internally divided a category to serve as the subject of a theory of gender justice." Critically discuss.

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: The division is real and the conclusion does not follow; what follows is a change in **method**, not the abandonment of the category.

The case for the claim. FACT: Intersectional analysis shows that gender is mediated by other structures. **Caste** operates through endogamy, labour, property, status and control of marriage and sexuality. **Class** operates through insecure work, unpaid labour and bargaining resources. **Religion and community** combine minority vulnerability with internal authority and personal-law disputes. **Disability** operates through dependency arrangements, accessibility and substituted decision-making. **Sexuality and gender identity** operate through compulsory heterosexuality, stigma and gender policing. **FACT: bell hooks** adds that dominant feminism can universalise privileged experience, so the centre misdescribes the margin.

Why intersectionality is not arithmetic. FACT: It does not add independent disadvantages. It asks how institutions produce a **distinct mechanism** at their intersection - which is why a gender-only remedy can miss harms created through caste, class, community, disability or sexuality altogether.

Why the conclusion still fails. ANALYSIS: Three replies. First, common claims to **dignity and equality** remain, and coalition is built on those rather than on uniformity of experience. Second, anti-discrimination practice already operates with **provisionally stabilised** categories, which is the strategic-essentialism position: a category may be used politically while its historical construction is conceded. Third, the objection proves too much - every social category is internally divided, so the argument would dissolve class, caste and citizenship alike.

What does follow. ANALYSIS: A methodological requirement: trace the **mechanism** through the mediating axis rather than appending a sentence about compounded disadvantage. In India, anti-caste analysis is not an optional illustration; it changes the account of how the gender order is reproduced. **FACT:** The caste doctrine itself is owned elsewhere - name the mechanism and route it.

The residue. CAUTION: Strategic essentialism is unstable: a category adopted for leverage hardens into a description and marginalises those it fits badly. The exchange is live and should be held open.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: "Women" survives as a political and legal category **kept internally diverse, historically constructed and open** - a working criterion, not a settled resolution.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a quotation stem is scored on how precisely the claim is granted before it is refused. Granting the division in full - five named axes with their mechanisms - and then showing that the inference to abandonment fails on three independent grounds is what produces a twenty-mark structure.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: position one line; the case seven lines; not arithmetic three lines; three replies five lines; what follows four lines; residue two lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** position -> the case granted in full -> intersectionality as mechanism -> three replies -> the methodological consequence -> residue -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** intersectional mediation; strategic essentialism; the working category criterion.
- **Evidence:** Crenshaw's method; bell hooks's margin-to-centre warning; the five mediating axes.
- **Distinction:** additive disadvantage against a distinct mechanism at the intersection.
- **Criticism:** the fragmentation objection, and the instability of strategic essentialism.

How to improve this answer

Add the observation that the objection **proves too much** early rather than late, since it is the cheapest of the three replies and buying space with it leaves room for the methodological consequence, which is where the marks concentrate. If two further lines are available, connect the working criterion to the five-column separation - sex characteristics, assignment, identity, expression, role - because that shows the category being kept open by a stated rule rather than by goodwill.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Can differential treatment of women be reconciled with the principle of equality? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Independent model answer

Position. ANALYSIS: Yes, and only under a stated test - because equality is a principle about **standing**, not about symmetry of classification.

Three conceptions. FACT: **Formal** equality applies the same rule and cannot see unequal starting positions.

Substantive equality attends to burdens and effective outcomes. **Relational** equality asks whether citizens can meet without domination, stigma or servility. **FACT:** Equality therefore need not mean identical treatment: pregnancy, unpaid care, inherited exclusion and violence may require differentiated support to secure equal standing and capability.

The dilemma. ANALYSIS: **Sameness** applies one sex-neutral rule and risks leaving the **male life-pattern** as a hidden norm inside it - uninterrupted employment, no caring responsibility, mobility without safety constraints.

Difference recognises the burden and risks **essentialising** it, so that protection becomes confinement. Both risks are real, which is what makes this a dilemma rather than an error.

The resolution. ANALYSIS: Ask not whether a rule classifies alike but whether it **alters capability, status and power**. Differential treatment is justified where it **removes a socially produced burden and enlarges equal standing without fixing a permanent gender essence**.

The test, in three questions. ANALYSIS: Is the burden socially produced, or is the measure premised on a natural incapacity? Does it enlarge standing and capability, or protect by confining? Is it proportionate and **revisable**, or does it fix a permanent category? A maternity provision passes all three; an inheritance exclusion presented as protection fails all three.

The objection. FACT: Reverse discrimination: differentiating in the opposite direction violates the same principle.

Reply: the principle protects equal standing, and a measure that removes a socially produced burden is not the mirror image of one that imposes it - the two differ in what they do to standing. **ANALYSIS:** The reply is bounded by proportionality and reviewability.

The residue. CAUTION: Judging which burdens are socially produced and which measures enlarge rather than confine is contested, and no procedure settles it. The revisability condition matters precisely because a wrong

judgment must remain correctable.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Reconciliation is possible, conditional and permanently under review: an unrevisable remedial category has become the essence it was designed to dismantle.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "reasons and justifications" asks for a criterion, not a stance. Supplying the three-question test and then applying it to a passing and a failing case demonstrates the criterion working, which is what converts an assertion into a justification.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: position one line; three conceptions five lines; dilemma four lines; resolution two lines; the test five lines; objection and reply four lines; residue two lines; verdict two lines.

- **Structure:** position -> three conceptions -> the dilemma -> the resolution -> the three-question test -> reverse-discrimination objection -> residue -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** formal, substantive and relational equality; transformative equality as the resolution.
- **Evidence:** Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill on law and custom; the maternity-provision and inheritance-exclusion contrast.
- **Distinction:** classification against standing.
- **Criticism:** the reverse-discrimination objection, bounded by proportionality and reviewability.

How to improve this answer

Add one line noting that Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill had already identified the structure of the difficulty - law and custom **jointly** manufacture the subjection - because it shows that the formal/substantive distinction has a history rather than being a modern convenience. If two further lines are available, connect the test to the three dimensions of a complete remedy, since a measure that passes all three questions may still fail if it operates in redistribution alone and leaves recognition and representation untouched.